MODULE G · PROPOSAL WRITING

G

Proposal Writing

The single most important skill in this role. Every fee we win, every client we keep, every relationship we extend begins here, on the page, in the words you choose.

G.0 · WHY THIS SECTION EXISTS

Why Proposal Writing Is the Single Most Important Skill

> *Every fee **Create The Edge** earns, every relationship we extend, every project that makes it to design begins in the proposal. The document is not paperwork. It is the moment the client decides whether you are the firm they trust with millions of dollars of capital, years of construction, and the daily operations of their facility.*

Most consulting firms treat the proposal as a sales brochure. They make it pretty, they pile on credentials, they recite their history, and they hope the prettiness wins the work. **Create The Edge does not write proposals that way.** Our proposal is a working instrument, designed to do four specific jobs, and every page of every proposal that leaves this firm must perform those jobs on the first read.

This module is the longest in the manual because proposal writing is the single skill that touches every other skill you will learn. It draws on the terminology of Section B, the sales philosophy of Section C, the client psychology of Section D, the discovery work of Section E, and the RFP-versus-RFQ judgment of Section F. Everything in this guide ladders up to your ability to write a proposal that a client signs, that operations can deliver, that finance can collect against, and that legal can defend.

❝ EXPERT INSIGHT

"We took out Create The Edge, we took out the I. They don't buy Create The Edge or foodservice equipment. They buy results to their problem. Every proposal you write needs to lead with their problem, not our resume."

· MARKETING DIRECTOR

FIGURE G.0.1 · THE FOUR THINGS A CREATE THE EDGE PROPOSAL MUST DO ON THE FIRST READ

1

FUNCTION

Mitigate Risk

Show the client exactly which operational, structural, and financial risks our involvement prevents. Risk reduction, not feature listing, is what justifies fee.

2

FUNCTION

Clarify Scope

State precisely what is in and out, phase by phase. Ambiguity here is the single largest source of fee write-offs and client disputes.

3

FUNCTION

Defend Fee

Show the math, not the magic. A defended fee is a paid fee. A fee that looks pulled from the air is the fee a client will negotiate down or refuse.

4

FUNCTION

Prove Coordination

Demonstrate that our work will integrate with the architect, MEP engineers, interior designer, and contractor. Coordination, not isolation, is what an AEC client buys.

RULE OF THE HOUSE

A **Create The Edge** proposal is institutional documentation. It is not a marketing brochure. If a sentence does not do one of the four jobs above, it should not be in the proposal. There is no exception, including any sentence about our history, our awards, or our office locations, unless that sentence directly connects to risk mitigation, scope clarity, fee defense, or coordination assurance.

What This Section Will Teach You to Do

By the end of Module G you will be able to take an intake call, classify the project correctly, identify the four to seven decision drivers behind the request, draft a two-paragraph opening that earns the right to be read, build a phased fee from first principles, defend that fee in front of [Department Manager]'s review, and submit on a three-business-day turnaround. You will also be able to spot the recurring errors that send proposals back for rework, so you can avoid them before they happen.

You will not learn this by reading once. You will learn it by writing proposals, getting feedback, rewriting them, and watching how the language and the logic harden over time. This module is your reference. The work itself is the teacher.

FROM THE FILES

The hit rate that defines the discipline. Industry average proposal-to-win conversion runs near 30 percent and demands roughly five proposals to win one engagement. **Create The Edge**'s current hit rate is approximately 80 percent on a 1.2:1 conversion ratio. That gap is not luck. It is the result of writing proposals that perform the four functions above on the first read, consistently, across every sector we serve.

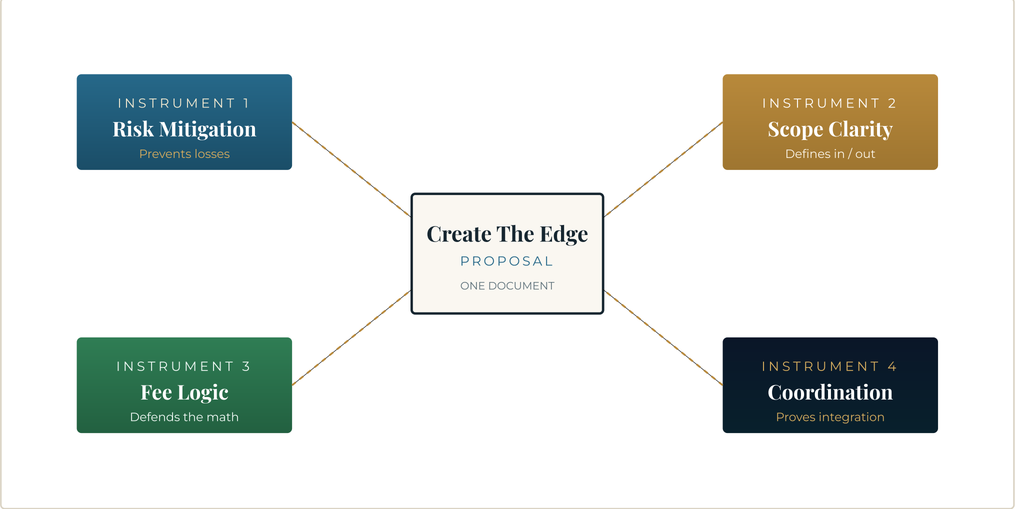
G.1 · THE FOUR-INSTRUMENT ARCHITECTURE

The Four Instruments Inside Every Proposal

> *A **Create The Edge** proposal is four documents pretending to be one. Once you can see them, you can write them. Once you can write them, you cannot un-see them in anyone else's work.*

Every proposal that leaves the firm contains four functional instruments. They share the same cover, the same letterhead, and the same envelope, but each instrument does a separate job. The order they appear is fixed. The relationship between them is fixed. Once you can see the four instruments clearly, you will write tighter proposals, your fees will hold up under negotiation, and [Department Manager]'s review cycle will compress.

FIGURE G.1.1 · THE FOUR-INSTRUMENT ARCHITECTURE, VISUALIZED



Instrument 1 · Risk Mitigation

The first reason a client signs a proposal is because the proposal makes them feel safer than not signing it. Risk Mitigation is the instrument that does that work. It identifies the operational, structural, regulatory, and financial risks the client is exposed to without expert involvement, and it explains how the work in the proposal eliminates or reduces each one.

- ✓ "Our review of the existing MEP loads will identify undersized branch circuits before equipment delivery, preventing the most common cause of equipment failure on day one."
- ✓ "BIM clash detection in Design Development will resolve duct-through-beam conflicts in software rather than in concrete, eliminating the change-order exposure that typically appears in Construction Documents."
- ✓ "The variance letter included with this proposal documents the non-standard finish at the soiled-laundry threshold so insurance carriers can underwrite the project without callbacks."

- ✗ "We have an excellent reputation for quality."
- ✗ "Our team has decades of experience."
- ✗ "We pride ourselves on attention to detail."
- ✗ "We will ensure a smooth process."
- ✗ "We are committed to your satisfaction."
- ✗ "Quality is our priority."

Notice the difference. The DO column points at a specific risk and the work that prevents it. The DON'T column makes claims about *us*. Risk mitigation language is always about *the client's exposure*, not *our character*.

Instrument 2 · Scope Clarity

Scope clarity is the instrument that lives in the Consultation Agreement and bleeds back into the cover letter. It states, phase by phase, exactly what we will produce, exactly when we will produce it, and exactly what is excluded. Ambiguity here is the single largest source of fee write-offs and client disputes that we see across the firm. If a deliverable is listed as part of Construction Documents in the cover letter but Construction Administration in the agreement, the client will read it the way that benefits them, and we will eat the difference.

> ☷ RULE OF THE HOUSE
>
> Every deliverable in the cover letter must appear, by the same name, in the same phase, in the consultation agreement. [Department Manager]'s review checks this match line by line. A mismatch is the most common reason a draft is returned.

Instrument 3 · Fee Logic

Fee Logic is the instrument that defends the math. A fee with no visible logic looks like a guess. A guess is the fee a client negotiates against. A fee with visible logic, broken into phases, tied to a sector rate and an equipment budget, looks like an engineered number. An engineered number is the fee a client signs. The fee table itself, the percent split

Instrument 4 · Coordination Assurance

Coordination Assurance is the instrument that proves to the architect and the engineers that our work will not blow up theirs. AEC clients have all worked with consultants who delivered beautiful kitchen plans that ignored the mechanical drawings, the structural ceiling height, or the interior designer's bar elevation. Our coordination paragraphs, the BIM/Revit references, the MEP load reviews, and the clash-detection commitments, all serve this instrument. It is also the reason the proposal names a coordinator on our team by role: the client wants to know who they will be on the phone with at 4:30 on a Friday afternoon.

> FROM THE FILES
>
> **How the instruments tend to fail.** When proposals get sent back, it is rarely all four instruments at once. It is typically one. Risk Mitigation fails when it slides into self-description. Scope Clarity fails when the cover letter and agreement disagree. Fee Logic fails when the percent split doesn't match the hours. Coordination fails when no one on our team is named. Knowing which instrument is breaking down lets you fix the proposal in minutes instead of rewriting from scratch.

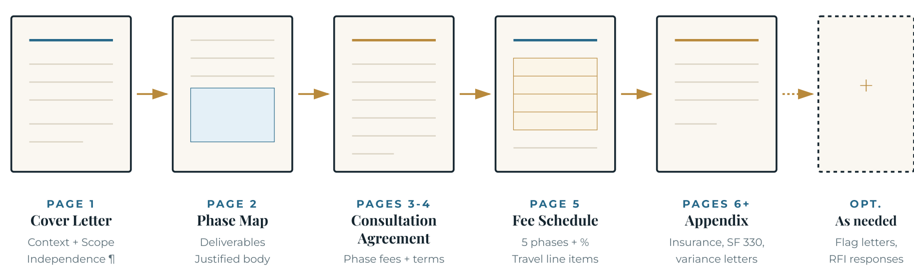
G.2 · DOCUMENT ANATOMY

What Is Inside a Create The Edge Proposal

> *There is a fixed running order, page by page. Once you internalize the order, you will recognize when a draft is missing a part, when a part is in the wrong place, and when a competitor has skipped a part entirely.*

The four instruments from G.1 do not appear as four separate documents. They are woven through a fixed running order of physical pages. Every proposal we send follows this order. The order itself is part of what makes the document feel professional on first contact: an architect, a school superintendent, a hotel asset manager all expect to see the same things in the same places. When they do, our document feels familiar even though they have never read it before.

FIGURE G.2.1 · THE STANDARD RUNNING ORDER OF A CREATE THE EDGE PROPOSAL



The running order is fixed. The page count varies. The reader expectations do not.

The Components, in Order

COMPONENT	WHAT IT CONTAINS	JOB IT DOES
Cover Letter, Page 1	Salutation. Two-paragraph opening: context (Why?) and scope (What?). Independence paragraph for the segment. Signature block.	Earns the right to be read. Establishes authority before the fee number appears.
Cover Letter, Page 2	Phase map showing the five phases with	Maps the scope into named phases the

	deliverable lists. Coordination paragraph. Body text justified.	reader can verify against the agreement.
Consultation Agreement	Phase fees, payment terms, exclusions, additional services rates, insurance limits, scope boundaries, termination terms.	The legally binding portion. Every deliverable in the letter appears here by the same name.
Fee Schedule	Total fee with the five-phase percentage split. Travel and expense line items separately listed. Hourly rate sheet for additional services.	Defends the math from first principles. Makes the fee feel engineered, not invented.
Appendix	Insurance certificates, SF 330 selected past projects on the client's bullseye, variance letters when scope requires them.	Backs every claim in the letter with documentary proof.
Optional Attachments	Flag letters for scope risks raised in the letter, RFI responses, equipment surveys for renovation work.	Closes loose ends before the client has to ask the question.

What This Document Is Not

✓ A CREATE THE EDGE PROPOSAL IS

- ✓ Institutional documentation, technical and direct
- ✓ A working instrument the client uses to decide
- ✓ A defended fee with visible math
- ✓ A scope contract with named deliverables
- ✓ Evidence of coordination across AEC trades

✕ A CREATE THE EDGE PROPOSAL IS NOT

- ✕ A marketing brochure with hero shots
- ✕ A history lesson about the firm
- ✕ An award shelf with credentials in lieu of substance
- ✕ A list of generic capabilities
- ✕ A vague restatement of the RFP

A draft arrives with the consultation agreement before the cover letter. This is not a small error. It signals to the reader that the document does not know who its audience is. The cover letter is the only place in the proposal where the reader can be persuaded. The agreement is where they verify. Persuasion before verification, always.

G.3 · THE DECISION MATRIX

Rational + Emotional Drivers, in Equal Measure

> *Before you write a word, you classify the project on two axes. Half the decision is metrics, half is meaning. Skip either half and the proposal will land in the wrong tone, at the wrong price, against the wrong competitor.*

Every project arrives at **Create The Edge** with two data sets buried inside it. The first set is rational: square footage, FTE counts, equipment budget, deadlines, sector type, delivery markers. The second set is emotional: what the client is trying to achieve in human terms, what they are afraid of losing, what they will be celebrated for if it goes well, what they will be blamed for if it goes badly. Both sets carry equal weight in the decision the client is about to make. Treat the proposal accordingly.

FIGURE G.3.1 · THE 50 / 50 DECISION MATRIX

RATIONAL · 50%

The Metrics

What the numbers tell you

- Square Footage · 50,000 SF School
- FTE / Bed Count · 852 beds
- Equipment Budget · $1.725 MM
- Critical Deadlines · bond cycle
- Sector Type · K-12, healthcare
- Delivery Markers · 30 / 60 / 90 / 100
- Regulatory Layer · JCAHO, USDA, code

EMOTIONAL · 50%

The Meaning

What success would feel like

- Made · outcomes that change lives
- Paid · measurable financial return
- Loved · recognition, recruiting

- Impact · who benefits, by how much
- Critical Event · why now, not later
- Fear · what failure costs them

Both columns must be extracted before drafting begins.

The Rational Half: What You Extract from the Documents

The rational data is sitting in the RFP, the architect's narrative, the program document, or the bond authorization. Your job is to extract it before you open a blank cover letter. Without the metrics, you cannot build a defended fee, you cannot size the kitchen, you cannot select the right SF 330 projects, and you cannot raise flags about scope-versus-budget gaps. The numbers come first because the numbers are checkable.

> When a 1,200-square-foot servery is paired with a 2,000-meal lunch projection, the math fails before the design starts. The flag must be raised in the proposal, not discovered in CD. [Department Manager]'s note: *"If the kitchen is undersized for the meal count, write it into the proposal as a question, not a problem. Questions earn meetings. Problems lose work."*

The Emotional Half: What You Extract from the Conversation

The emotional data is rarely in the documents. It comes out of the intake call, the site visit, the questions you ask before you write. **[Department Manager]'s principle is to listen first.** The Kleenex analogy makes the point fastest: a person buying tissues is buying paper, but the reason they walked into the store is to keep their family from getting sick. The paper is the rational layer. The family is the emotional layer. You sell tissues by acknowledging both.

FIGURE G.3.2 · THE ISHIKAWA FIVE-LAYER FRAME, APPLIED TO THREE SECTORS

SECTOR	RATIONAL LAYER (WHAT THEY SAY)	EMOTIONAL LAYER (WHAT THEY MEAN)
K-12 School	"We need a kitchen that serves 1,400 students in a 30-minute window."	"I cannot have another year where parents complain about lunch on social media."
Senior Living	"We need an upgraded servery for our memory care residents."	"Our occupancy rate is tied to family tours. The food has to read as five-star, not institutional."
Correctional	"We need a kitchen that produces 1,500 meals three times a day."	"Food incidents are how riots start. I need a kitchen the warden can run without surprises."

How to Surface Each Half on the Intake Call

BOTH LAYERS

- ✓ "Walk me through what success looks like at opening week."
- ✓ "What would have to be true for this project to be considered a win by your board?"
- ✓ "What is the most expensive mistake the prior consultant made on a project like this?"
- ✓ "Who in your organization is most worried about this, and why?"
- ✓ "If we were having this conversation 18 months from now, what would the headline be?"

SURFACE

- ✗ "What is your budget?" (asked too early, kills trust)
- ✗ "What kind of equipment do you want?" (asks them to do our job)
- ✗ "When do you want to start?" (no context, no value)
- ✗ "Have you worked with a foodservice consultant before?" (interview tone)
- ✗ "What does your kitchen look like now?" (a survey, not a discovery)

❝ EXPERT INSIGHT

"The baby seat in the back of the car is the emotional layer. The tires are the rational layer. A great salesperson sells tires and never mentions the baby. A great consultant designs for both, and the client signs because they feel understood, not just quoted."

· MARKETING DIRECTOR, TRAINING NOTES

G.4 · THE EMOTIONAL LAYER

Made / Paid / Loved · [Department Manager]'s Three-Pillar Frame

> *Every client is moved by some combination of three forces: lives changed, money returned, recognition earned. Identify which mix your client cares about, and the proposal almost writes itself.*

[Department Manager]'s softening of Grant Cardone's "Made / Paid / Laid" frame retains its compactness while removing the locker-room edge. The three words are a working tool: when you write the cover letter, the opening paragraphs should signal which of the three the client is most driven by. Every sector mixes the three differently, and every individual decision-maker inside the client organization weights them differently again.

FIGURE G.4.1 · THE THREE PILLARS, WITH EXAMPLE LANGUAGE

Which Pillar Dominates, by Sector

SECTOR	PRIMARY PILLAR	SECONDARY PILLAR	HOW TO OPEN THE LETTER
K-12 / Public School	Made	Paid	Lead with student outcomes, follow with the labor cost or reimbursement angle.
Healthcare / Senior Living	Made	Loved	Lead with resident or patient experience, follow with the marketing/recruiting story.

	PILLAR	PILLAR	LETTER
Hospitality / Hotels	Paid	Loved	Lead with revenue per available room and labor optimization, follow with brand experience.
Country Club	Loved	Paid	Lead with member experience and recognition, follow with membership retention math.
Correctional	Paid	Made	Lead with operational risk and cost control, follow with reduced incident outcomes.
Military / Federal	Made	Paid	Lead with readiness and force projection, follow with lifecycle cost.
Corporate / Catering	Paid	Loved	Lead with capital efficiency, follow with employee experience as recruitment tool.

Made / Paid / Loved in Opening Sentences

RIGHT PILLAR

- **K-12 (Made-led):** "This kitchen modernization will support a 35% increase in student participation while reducing service-line waiting times below the 4-minute district standard."
- **Hotel (Paid-led):** "The proposed F&B reconfiguration is engineered to lift bar revenue per occupied room by an estimated 12% while reducing back-of-house labor by 1.4 full-time equivalents."
- **Senior Living (Made + Loved):** "The marketplace design is structured to elevate the dining experience to the standard that supports the facility's five-star tour conversion targets."

PILLAR

- "We are pleased to present this proposal."
- "Create The Edge has been in business for decades."
- "We are excited about the opportunity to work with you."
- "We have decades of experience in your sector."
- "Our team is highly qualified."
- "We look forward to your response."

RULE OF THE HOUSE

The opening sentence of the cover letter must name the client's primary pillar. If it does not, rewrite it. The opening sentence is the most expensive sentence in the proposal because it determines whether the second sentence gets read.

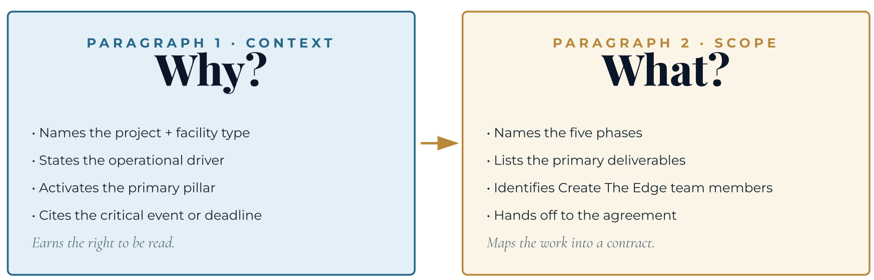
G.5 · THE TWO-PARAGRAPH RULE

Two Paragraphs. Context, then Scope.

> *Every cover letter opens with exactly two paragraphs before anything else appears. The first answers Why? The second answers What? If you cannot fit your opening into two paragraphs, you do not yet understand the project well enough to write it.*

The two-paragraph rule is the single tightest constraint **Create The Edge** places on its writers. It is not stylistic preference. It is the structure that forces the discipline of starting with the client's situation before pivoting to our work. Without the constraint, openings sprawl into self-description, history, and credential listing. With the constraint, the opening becomes the most useful page in the proposal.

FIGURE G.5.1 · THE TWO-PARAGRAPH ANATOMY



Strong vs. Weak Openings, Side by Side

STANDARD

- ✓ **Context:** "This renovation will modernize the kitchen and laundry infrastructure at Main Sail Resort to support the projected 18% increase in seasonal occupancy beginning Memorial Day 2027 while reducing long-term capital, labor, and utility costs."
- ✓ **Scope:** "Create The Edge will provide Programming, Schematic Design, Design Development, Construction Documents, Bidding/Negotiation, and Construction Administration services for the kitchen and laundry, coordinated through the Senior Project Manager and Marketing Director as primary client liaison."

- ✕ "We are pleased to present this proposal for your consideration."
- ✕ "Thank you for the opportunity to bid on this exciting project."
- ✕ "We hope to meet your expectations and look forward to working with you."
- ✕ "Create The Edge is one of the leading consultants in the industry..."
- ✕ "Founded in 1962, Create The Edge has..."
- ✕ "Our firm prides itself on..."

The Hard Rules of Narrative

1

RULE

No em dashes

Anywhere. Ever. Use semicolons, parentheses, or full sentences. The em dash is a habit, not a punctuation mark.

2

RULE

No juvenile phrasing

"X is located in..." reads like a fourth-grade book report. Use direct construction: "X serves the Birmingham AL market."

3

RULE

U.S. state abbreviations

Always GA, NC, FL, AL · never "Georgia, USA" or "Birmingham, Alabama." This is a professional shorthand the AEC industry uses.

4

RULE

Three-word tone

Confident. Restrained. Informed. If a sentence reads as breathless, anxious, or chatty, rewrite it.

If [Department Manager]'s review hands back a draft with the comment "lead with them, not us," it means the first paragraph failed the context test. The fix is rarely to add words. It is almost always to delete the first three sentences and start at sentence four, which is usually the sentence about the client's actual situation.

[Department Manager]'s Core Philosophy, Restated

❝ EXPERT INSIGHT

"We took out Create The Edge, we took out the I. They don't buy Create The Edge or foodservice equipment. They buy results to their problem. Every cover letter you write that starts with us is a cover letter that has not earned the right to be read."

· MARKETING DIRECTOR

G.6 · THE FIVE-PHASE STRUCTURE

The Five Phases, the Percentages, and Why They Exist

> *Five phases. Each one a risk shield against a different failure mode. The percentages reflect where the labor actually lands, where the documentation risk concentrates, and where the client benefits most from our involvement.*

Every **Create The Edge** proposal larger than a small renovation breaks the fee into five phases. The order is fixed. The names are fixed. The percentage splits vary by sector and by negotiation, but two reference splits are sufficient to handle most of what crosses your desk. Understanding what each phase does, what it shields against, and what hours it consumes is what separates a defended fee from a guessed one.

FIGURE G.6.1 · THE FIVE PHASES AS RISK SHIELDS

The Two Reference Splits

You will see two phase splits in **Create The Edge** proposals. The first is the operating-system default, used when no special pressure exists on the project. The second is a real working example from the Major Transportation Hospitality Project Tampa engagement, where negotiation moved more weight into Construction Documents and Construction Administration. Both are valid. Knowing when to use which is part of the judgment you will develop.

FIGURE G.6.2 · THE TWO STANDARD SPLITS, COMPARED

PHASE	CODE	DEFAULT OS SPLIT	TRANSPORTATION HOSPITALITY PROJECT VARIANT	WHY IT DIFFERS
Schematic Design	SD	20%	20%	Stable across both
Design Development	DD	25%	25%	Stable across both
Construction Documents	CD	30%	35%	Tampa scope required heavier doc package
Bid / Negotiate	BN	10%	2%	[Major Transportation Hospitality Project] uses single-source furnish; minimal bid cycle
Construction Admin	CA	15%	18%	Tampa added LEED + WELL coordination during construction

> ☷ RULE OF THE HOUSE
>
> The default OS split is your starting position. The Delta variant is a negotiated reality. When you write a draft proposal, you use the default. When [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] adjusts the split based on the client's actual procurement model, you update the split and the math regenerates automatically. Both are valid; neither is improvised.

Phase Count Variations

3

PHASE COUNT

Small renovation

Equipment replacement or like-for-like swap. SD compressed, DD skipped, CD light, CA light. Use only when client confirms no MEP or structural change.

4

PHASE COUNT

Renovation w/ Programming

Add Programming or Equipment Survey ahead of SD. Renovation jobs almost always need this because the existing conditions are not in the drawing set.

5

PHASE COUNT

New construction (default)

SD, DD, CD, BN, CA. The default architecture, used on most multi-million dollar projects.

6–7

PHASE COUNT

Complex / multi-site

Phased deliveries (campus rollouts, multi-property hotel groups, multi-site CMS school programs). Each delivery phase tracks 30/60/90/100 milestones.

Programming versus Schematic, Cleared Up

✓ PROGRAMMING IS

- ✓ Pre-design report mapping codes, regulations, and FTE math
- ✓ Narrative framing of operational requirements
- ✓ The deliverable that sizes the kitchen before drawings exist
- ✓ A standalone phase priced separately, often required on renovations

× PROGRAMMING IS NOT

- × The same thing as Schematic Design
- × A bubble diagram or block layout (those are SD outputs)
- × Free work bundled into SD
- × Optional when the client has not provided a current equipment inventory

Meeting Counts and the Adjustment Rule

The default meeting counts are: **SD** 1-2, **DD** 1-2, **CD** 1-2, **BN** 1, **CA** as per project schedule (not bundled into base fee). If a client requires more meetings than the default, the fee must be adjusted upward. This is non-negotiable. Additional meetings are billed at the senior PM rate ($225/hr standard, $250 for senior, $275 for principal involvement).

COMMON FAILURE

A client asks for "weekly check-ins" through Design Development. The default DD allocation is 1-2 meetings. A 12-week DD with weekly check-ins is 12 meetings, ten over the default. Ten additional meetings at $225/hr (assume 2 hours per meeting including prep) is $4,500 in unbilled labor. If the fee is not adjusted at the time the client asks, the firm absorbs the difference. **Ask the question on the call. Adjust the proposal before it is signed.**

WRITING 8 OF 54 ONLY

G.7 · THE COVER LETTER SYSTEM

The Cover Letter, Block by Block

> *The cover letter is two pages, never more. It opens with the two-paragraph rule, names the five phases with their deliverables, contains the segment-appropriate independence paragraph, and closes with a signature block that names the responsible Create The Edge team.*

The cover letter is the persuasion instrument. The consultation agreement that follows is the verification instrument. If the letter is doing its job, the reader signs the agreement because they already believed the work on page one. The letter is structured into six blocks. Every **Create The Edge** letter contains these six blocks in this order.

FIGURE G.7.1 · THE SIX-BLOCK COVER LETTER

#	BLOCK	WHAT IT CONTAINS	WHY IT IS THERE
1	**Letterhead & Date**	[Company Address], phone, web. Date in standard format. Re: line stating the project name and city.	Provides the legal anchor. The proposal lives in a documentary chain.
2	**Salutation**	Direct address to the decision-maker. Honorific if known. "Dear Mr. Lawson" not "Dear Sir/Madam."	Signals research. We know who the reader is.
3	**Context Paragraph (Why?)**	The two-paragraph opening from G.5. Activates the primary pillar. Cites the critical event.	Earns the right to be read.
4	**Scope Paragraph (What?)**	Names the five phases, lists the primary deliverables, identifies the Create The Edge team members by role.	Maps the work into a contract the client can verify.
5	**Independence Paragraph**	The segment-appropriate paragraph from G.8. F&B framing for hospitality bars;	Establishes fiduciary stance. Differentiates from dealer-tied competitors.

		Foodservice framing for K-12, healthcare, correctional.	
6	**Signature Block**	[Department Manager] or [Company Owner] for client-facing; PM as alternate signatory; insurance limits stated; contact direct phone and email.	Names accountability. Closes the persuasion loop.

An Annotated Cover Letter, Page One

LETTER

1

CONTEXT + SCOPE

Renovation

Create The Edge
[Company Address]
[Company Phone] · [Company Website]

15 September 2026

Mr. Robert Lawson
Vice President, Capital Projects
Main Sail Resort Group
Myrtle Beach SC 29577

Re: Foodservice and Laundry Renovation, Main Sail Resort, Myrtle Beach SC

Dear Mr. Lawson:

This renovation will modernize the kitchen and laundry infrastructure at Main Sail Resort to support the projected 18% increase in seasonal occupancy beginning Memorial Day 2027 while reducing long-term capital, labor, and utility costs. The existing kitchen, sized for the original 110-key program, has been operating at 145 keys for three seasons; the laundry, sized for 150 keys, is currently dependent on outsourced overflow at a recurring cost of approximately $84,000 per season.

Create The Edge will provide Schematic Design, Design Development, Construction Documents, Bidding and Negotiation support, and Construction Administration services for the kitchen and laundry, coordinated through the Senior Project Manager and Marketing Director as primary client liaison. A separate variance letter is included addressing the soiled-laundry threshold detail required by the [State Health Department].

Annotation: Sentence one names the operational driver (occupancy increase) and the cost reduction frame (capital, labor, utility). Sentence two adds the rational metric (145 keys against a 110-key kitchen) and the financial pain ($84K/season overflow). Paragraph two names every phase, the team members, and flags an attachment. No word is wasted.

☷ RULE OF THE HOUSE

Page one of the cover letter is left-aligned. Page two is fully justified. This is [Department Manager]'s typography standard, and it carries forward from the firm's pre-2020 format. The rationale: page one is conversational; page two is contractual. The visual shift signals the transition.

G.8 · INDEPENDENCE PARAGRAPHS

The Six Segment Independence Paragraphs

> *Every proposal contains an independence paragraph. The wording shifts by sector to match the reader's framing. Use F&B language for hospitality bars. Use Foodservice language for everything else. Mixing them up signals that we did not read our own RFP.*

Independence is the single most durable differentiator **Create The Edge** has. We carry no manufacturer affiliations. We earn no equipment commissions. Our only product is a coordinated, efficient design defended by the math. Every proposal states this position explicitly. The wording varies by sector because the reader's expectations vary. A hotel asset manager reads "Foodservice" as catering; a K-12 director reads "F&B" as luxury. Pick the right framing and the sentence lands.

FIGURE G.8.1 · THE THREE FEATURES OF INDEPENDENT CONSULTING

1

FEATURE

No manufacturer affiliations

We are not a representative, agent, or partner of any equipment manufacturer. Our specifications are driven by performance requirements, not supplier relationships.

2

FEATURE

No equipment sales or commissions

We do not sell equipment and we do not receive commissions from equipment sales. Our fee is the only revenue we earn from your project.

3

FEATURE

Unbiased technical expertise

Every recommendation in our specifications is defendable on operational, lifecycle, and code grounds. We have no financial reason to recommend a piece of equipment we do not believe in.

The Six Sector Variants, Side by Side

STANDARD LANGUAGE

Create The Edge is an independent foodservice design firm. We carry no manufacturer affiliations, sell no equipment, and receive no commissions on equipment specified in your facility. Our recommendations are driven by your students' nutritional outcomes, your kitchen staff's operational efficiency, and the long-term cost of ownership your district carries on its capital budget. We work for you, not for a dealer.

Healthcare / Senior Living

STANDARD LANGUAGE

Create The Edge operates as an independent foodservice consultant with no manufacturer ties and no equipment commissions. Our specifications are written to your infection-control standards, JCAHO compliance obligations, and resident or patient experience targets. The design we recommend is the design that serves your operating model over a 15 to 20 year capital cycle.

Hospitality / Country Club (F&B framing)

STANDARD LANGUAGE

Create The Edge is independent in the strictest sense in the F&B design industry. We do not represent equipment manufacturers, we do not sell equipment, and we do not earn commissions on specified product. Our fee is the only revenue we draw from your project. This independence is what allows us to engineer a bar that maximizes revenue per square foot and a back-of-house line that minimizes the labor your operator will recruit against in a tight market.

Correctional

STANDARD LANGUAGE

Create The Edge is an independent foodservice design firm with no manufacturer affiliations. In a correctional setting, this independence is operationally critical: equipment selections are driven by durability, security integration, and long-term reliability rather than by dealer inventory. Our specifications protect your facility's daily operation and the safety of both staff and residents.

Military / Federal

Create The Edge is an independent foodservice design firm with no equipment representation, no manufacturer affiliations, and no commission structure. For federal procurement, our independence supports full compliance with conflict-of-interest standards. The design we deliver is engineered for readiness, lifecycle cost, and the no-maintenance reliability standard your operating model requires.

Corporate / Catering

STANDARD LANGUAGE

Create The Edge is an independent foodservice consultant. We are not an equipment dealer and do not earn commissions on equipment specified for your facility. This independence allows us to recommend the configuration that best fits your daily service model, your capital constraints, and the labor market your operator is hiring against.

Choosing the Right Paragraph

✓ DECISION RULE

- ✓ If the primary scope is a bar or restaurant in a hotel or club: use F&B framing
- ✓ If the primary scope is institutional foodservice (school, hospital, prison, military, corporate cafeteria): use Foodservice framing
- ✓ If the project has both (e.g., a hotel with a hotel restaurant and a banquet kitchen): use F&B in the cover letter and Foodservice in the scope sub-paragraphs as appropriate
- ✓ When uncertain, ask [Department Manager] before sending

✕ COMMON MISTAKES

- ✕ F&B language in a K-12 proposal (reads as luxury bias)
- ✕ Foodservice language in a country club bar proposal (reads as institutional)
- ✕ Both paragraphs in the same proposal (signals confusion)
- ✕ Generic "we are independent" without naming the absence of commissions or affiliations
- ✕ Omitting the paragraph entirely (loses the primary differentiator)

[Department Manager]'s review will reject any proposal that uses F&B framing for a school. The reverse, Foodservice framing for a hotel bar, is more common and also rejected. The framing word is not decorative. It signals which industry the writer thinks they are in. Get it wrong and the reader assumes the rest of the proposal was written by someone who did not read their RFP.

G.9 · THE CONSULTATION AGREEMENT

The Consultation Agreement, Block by Block

> *The cover letter persuades. The consultation agreement contracts. Every deliverable in the letter must appear by the same name in the same phase in the agreement. Mismatches are how fee write-offs are born.*

The Consultation Agreement is the legally binding section of the proposal. Where the cover letter speaks in narrative, the agreement speaks in defined terms. Where the letter persuades, the agreement contracts. The discipline of writing the agreement is simple in concept and exacting in execution: every commitment in the letter must map, one-to-one, to a line in the agreement. If the letter says "we will produce equipment specifications during Design Development," the agreement must say the same thing in the same phase using language a reviewer cannot reinterpret.

FIGURE G.9.1 · THE EIGHT BLOCKS OF A CONSULTATION AGREEMENT

#	BLOCK	WHAT IT CONTAINS	FAILURE MODE IF SKIPPED
1	**Parties & Project**	Legal name of client entity. Project name, address, scope summary.	Wrong entity = wrong AR collection. [Department Manager] has seen this.
2	**Phase Definitions**	SD, DD, CD, BN, CA. Each phase opens with its deliverables list. Programming or Equipment Survey added when applicable.	Deliverable promised in wrong phase = scope creep, no extra fee.
3	**Fee Schedule**	Total fee. Phase percentage split. Payment trigger per phase (typically at phase completion or 30/60/90 milestone).	Vague trigger = collection delay; firm absorbs working capital.

			IF SKIPPED
4	**Exclusions**	Items NOT in scope. Always cite: kitchen ventilation engineering, structural engineering, hazardous waste removal, third-party permitting fees.	Client assumes inclusion. Free work in CA phase.
5	**Additional Services**	Hourly rates table for any work beyond the contracted scope: Principal $275, Sr PM $250, PM $225, Sr Production $250, QC $200, Coordinator $150, REVIT $160, Specifications $120, Admin $100.	No rate table = no recourse when client asks for extra meetings.
6	**Travel & Expenses**	$1,600/day site visit fee. $0.665/mile beyond 50 miles. $225/hr for additional meetings beyond contract count. Line items, not bundled.	Bundled travel = client thinks it is unlimited; firm eats overage.
7	**Insurance Limits**	Professional Liability $2M / $4M. General Liability $3M / $6M. Certificate of Insurance available on signing.	Missing limits = client cannot get the project approved by their carrier.
8	**Signature & Acceptance**	Client signature line. Date. Notice of Acceptance trigger.	No acceptance trigger = no contract; firm has done work without a deal.

The Letter-to-Agreement Match Check

☷ RULE OF THE HOUSE

Before sending, read the cover letter and the agreement side by side. Every deliverable named in the letter must appear in the agreement under the same phase, using the same noun. "Equipment specifications" in the letter and "equipment schedule" in the agreement is a mismatch. [Department Manager]'s review will catch it. Save the cycle: catch it yourself first.

- ✓ Letter: "During Design Development, we will produce a coordinated equipment plan including dimensioned layouts and MEP load schedules."
- ✓ Agreement DD phase: "Coordinated equipment plan with dimensioned layouts and MEP load schedules."
- ✓ Both use the same nouns: *coordinated equipment plan*, *dimensioned layouts*, *MEP load schedules*.

- ✗ Letter: "Our team will deliver design drawings during DD."
- ✗ Agreement DD phase: "Equipment schedules and rough-in points."
- ✗ The client reads "design drawings" and expects fully rendered plans. The agreement promises a schedule. Dispute incoming.

G.10 · FEE CALCULATION MASTER LOGIC

Three Methods to Calculate a Defended Fee

> *Method A: square feet times sector rate. Method B: equipment budget times percentage. Method C: laundry pounds-per-hour times capacity. Use the method that fits the scope. Show the math. The math is the defense.*

A defended fee is a paid fee. A guessed fee is a fee the client negotiates against. Every **Create The Edge** fee uses one of three calculation methods, and the method is visible in the proposal. The client can replicate your math on the back of an envelope. That replicability is what makes the fee feel engineered, and engineered fees survive procurement review.

FIGURE G.10.1 · THE THREE METHODS, AT A GLANCE

METHOD A	METHOD B	METHOD C
SF × Sector Rate	**Equip Budget × %**	**Laundry 15-lb**
Used on new construction	*Used on short-cycle / equip-only*	*Used on laundry/linen scope*
Step 1: Kitchen SF × $/SF	Step 1: Equipment budget	Step 1: Keys × 15 lbs
Step 2: + Cooler/Freezer	Step 2: × sector fee %	Step 2: ÷ 7 working hrs
Step 3: × sector fee %	Step 3: Round + line items	Step 3: Size washers + dryers
DEFAULT METHOD	RENOVATIONS	HOSPITALITY · SENIOR LIVING

Method A · Square Foot × Sector Rate (Worked Example)

STEP	INPUT	CALCULATION	RESULT
1	Kitchen size from program	1,167 SF × $300/SF (school rate)	$350,100
2	Add walk-in cooler/freezer	$350,100 + $49,200	$399,300 estimated equipment
3	Apply sector fee percentage	$399,300 × 4%	**$15,972 Fee**

Method B · Equipment Budget × Percentage (Worked Example)

1	Equipment budget from client or estimate	$270,000 (Miami Dade County Courthouse)	**$270,000**
2	Apply percentage (correctional, high-security)	$270,000 × 6.4%	**$17,400 Fee**

Method C · Laundry (the 15-pound Rule)

For hospitality and senior living projects with on-site laundry, the calculation is volume-driven. Every occupied room generates 15 pounds of laundry per day. The kitchen of laundry math is: convert daily pounds into lbs-per-working-hour, then size washers and dryers to meet that hourly demand.

STEP	FORMULA	MAIN SAIL (200 KEYS)	150-KEY BOUTIQUE
1. Daily pounds	Keys × 15	3,000 lbs/day	2,250 lbs/day
2. Hourly demand	Daily ÷ 7 working hrs	429 lbs/hr	322 lbs/hr
3. Washers needed	200-lb capacity, 45-min cycle = 267 lbs/hr each	2 washers	2 washers
4. Dryers needed	200-lb capacity, 60-min cycle = 200 lbs/hr each	3 dryers	2 dryers

FROM THE FILES

The Main Sail Resort laundry math, applied. [Department Manager]'s working example: 200 keys × 15 lbs = 3,000 lbs per day, requiring 200-lb dryers to meet the hourly demand within a 7-hour service window. The specialist equipment in the spec includes ozone systems for sanitization, floor troughs, washer-extractors, and high-capacity tumblers. The same kitchen of math drives the laundry-room SF allocation: roughly 299 SF clean / 242 SF soiled at 150 keys.

The Sector Reference Table

SECTOR	$/SF MULTIPLIER	FEE % RANGE	PHASE NOTES
K-12 School	$300 - $325	4% - 6%	Programming + SD + DD + CD + BN + CA

	MULTIPLIER	RANGE	
Correctional	$350 (unless >10K SF)	5% - 7%	CA % increased for security exposure
Hospitality	$325	3.5% - 5%	F&B storage + zero-step bartending
Military	Industry SF cost	5% general	Standard 5 + heightened security premium
Catering / Warming	$200 - $250	5% general	Excludes heavy cooking documentation
Healthcare / Senior Living	Industry SF cost	5% general	Infection control + reliability focus

COMMON FAILURE

Using Method A on a renovation that has no good square-foot baseline. The existing kitchen may be 1,800 SF but only 1,100 SF is being renovated. Multiplying the wrong SF by the sector rate inflates the fee, the client rejects, and we lose to a competitor who used Method B against the equipment budget. **Match the method to the scope, not the comfort of the writer.**

G.11 · WORKING FEE CALCULATOR

Live Fee Calculator (Method A: Population-Driven)

> *Below is a working version of the Create The Edge Fee Chart. Edit the input cells. The phase splits and the total fee recalculate as you type. Built directly from the master fee chart that lives in the Drive folder.*

The calculator below replicates the structure of the master Fee Chart workbook. The inputs drive the kitchen square footage, the equipment budget, and the rounded fee. The phase split applies the program/concept + 5-phase structure used on schools and similar institutional work.

Method A · Population-Driven Fee Calculator

Enter the population, participation rate, and unit costs. The calculator derives the kitchen SF and the recommended fee. Edit the percent split for non-standard phase distributions.

Inputs

Population	2000
Participation (decimal)	0.35
Peak ½-hour participation (decimal)	0.5
Seating inefficiency factor	0.85
SF per seat	18
$/SF Kitchen	325
$/SF Bar	175
$/SF Market	175
Bar SF	270
Market SF	104
Fee Percentage	5

Derived Values

Average Daily Participation	**700**

Number of Seats	**412**
Kitchen SF	**7,416 SF**
Total SF (Kitchen + Bar + Market)	**7,790 SF**
Equipment Total	**$2,475,650**

Phase Split

PHASE	DEFAULT %	FEE ALLOCATION
Programming / Concept	7 %	$8,665
Schematic Design	18 %	$22,281
Design Development	35 %	$43,324
Construction Documents	22 %	$27,232
Bid / Negotiations	3 %	$3,713
Construction Administration	15 %	$18,567
Check Total	100%	**Should = 100%**

Recommended Fee **$123,783**

RULE OF THE HOUSE

The calculator is a starting position, never the final fee. [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] will review the inputs against the project's actual program. Population figures from old occupancy data, participation rates from outdated benchmarks, or peak-hour assumptions that do not match the operating model can all distort the output. **Verify the inputs against the client's most recent operating data before quoting.**

G.12 · WORKING LABOR CALCULATOR

Live 5-Phase Labor Calculator (Major Transportation Hospitality Project Tampa Model)

> *The fee total is one number. The labor breakdown that defends it is another. Below is the working five-phase labor calculator, pre-loaded with the Major Transportation Hospitality Project Tampa data. Edit the percent commitment cells. The hours and cost recalculate per phase, per person.*

Where the fee calculator answers *how much?*, the labor calculator answers *where does the work actually go?* Every phase has a total fee, an average rate, and a percentage allocation across the team. The Major Transportation Hospitality Project Tampa engagement is the working reference: $31,750 total fee distributed across five phases with named team members in each.

FIGURE G.12.1 · MAJOR TRANSPORTATION HOSPITALITY PROJECT TAMPA REFERENCE ALLOCATION

PHASE	FEE	HOURS	TEAM ALLOCATION
SD · Schematic Design	$6,350	25	JC 10% · BD 90%
DD · Design Development	$9,525	47	JC 6% · BD 32% · BP 29% · JM 33% (6 meetings)
CD · Construction Docs	$9,525	46	JC 5% · BD 42% · BP 10% · JM 32% · HS 11% (8 meetings)
BN · Bid / Negotiation	$1,587.50	10	JM 100%
CA · Construction Admin	$4,762.50	21	JC 12% · BD 42% · AF 46%
Total	$31,750	149	5-person team

Live 5-Phase Labor Calculator

Enter the phase fee and the percent commitment per team member. Hours, cost, and the check-sum recalculate automatically.

Phase: Schematic Design (SD)

Phase Fee	6350

Company Owner, FCSI · President	$275	10 %	2.3	$635
Senior Project Manager · VP	$250	90 %	22.9	$5,715
Ben Pierce, FCSI Assoc. · PM	$225	0 %	0	$0
Josh McComb · Coordinator	$150	0 %	0	$0
Howard Stanford, FCSI · Production	$250	0 %	0	$0
Annlyn Fletcher, FCSI · QC/Specs	$200	0 %	0	$0
Check		100%	**25.2**	**$6,350**

Phase: Design Development (DD)

Phase Fee: 9525

PERSON	RATE	% COMMITMENT	HOURS	COST
Company Owner · President	$275	6 %	2.1	$572
Senior VP	$250	32 %	12.2	$3,048
Ben Pierce · PM	$225	29 %	12.3	$2,762
Josh McComb · Coordinator	$150	33 %	21	$3,143
Howard Stanford · Production	$250	0 %	0	$0
Annlyn Fletcher · QC/Specs	$200	0 %	0	$0
Check		100%	**47.5**	**$9,525**

Phase: Construction Documents (CD)

Phase Fee: 9525

PERSON	RATE	% COMMITMENT	HOURS	COST
Company Owner · President	$275	5 %	1.7	$476
Senior VP	$250	42 %	16	$4,001
Ben Pierce · PM	$225	10 %	4.2	$953
Josh McComb · Coordinator	$150	32 %	20.3	$3,048
Howard Stanford · Production	$250	11 %	4.2	$1,048
Annlyn Fletcher · QC/Specs	$200	0 %	0	$0
Check		100%	**46.5**	**$9,525**

Phase: Bid / Negotiate (BN)

Phase Fee: 1587.5

Josh McComb · Coordinator	$150	100 %	10.6	$1,588
Check		100%	**10.6**	**$1,588**

Phase: Construction Administration (CA)

Phase Fee 4762.5

PERSON	RATE	% COMMITMENT	HOURS	COST
Company Owner · President	$275	12 %	2.1	$572
Senior VP	$250	42 %	8	$2,000
Annlyn Fletcher · QC/Specs	$200	46 %	11	$2,191
Check		100%	**21**	**$4,763**

Total Project Fee **$31,750**

FROM THE FILES

Why this calculator exists. A defended fee survives review when the math beneath it is visible. When [Department Manager], [Company Owner], or Cathey signs off on a fee, they are not just checking the total. They are checking whether the labor distribution matches the work actually required. A CD phase with no Production Manager is suspect. A BN phase with the principal at 50% is suspect. The percent commitment cells are the test, not the totals.

G.13 · TRAVEL & EXPENSE LINE ITEMS

Travel and Expense: Always a Line Item, Never a Bundle

> *Travel, mileage beyond 50 miles, and additional meetings beyond contract count are NEVER bundled into the base fee. They are line items in the agreement. Bundling them turns variable cost into fixed cost. The firm absorbs the variance every time.*

The reason for this rule is simple: travel and meeting counts are variable, the base fee is fixed. When a client decides three months into a project that they want weekly check-ins instead of the contracted monthly cadence, that decision adds cost. If the cost has nowhere to land in the agreement, the firm absorbs it. If the cost lands on a pre-defined line item, the client signs a change order and the work continues.

FIGURE G.13.1 · THE STANDARD TRAVEL AND EXPENSE RATE CARD

$1,600

PER DIEM

PM Site Visit

Full-day PM site visit rate. Covers travel time, on-site time, and report-back time. Used for both scheduled CA visits and ad-hoc client requests.

$0.665

PER MILE

Beyond 50 Miles

IRS standard mileage rate for vehicle travel beyond the 50-mile radius of the staffing office. Calculated round-trip.

$225

PER HOUR

Additional Meetings

Per-hour rate for meetings beyond the contract count. Standard PM rate. Use the senior PM rate ($250) when the client requests [Department Manager] or [Company Owner] specifically.

Major Transportation Hospitality Project Travel Reference

The Major Transportation Hospitality Project Tampa engagement shipped with a discrete travel cost block that becomes a useful reference for multi-location institutional work.

Robert Scheibly travel	Tallahassee FL based; multiple site visits to Tampa	$10,021
Howard Stanford travel	Lutz / Tampa FL based; production reviews on site	$5,425
LEED / WELL coordination	Specialist time for sustainability documentation	$12,150
Total expenses		**$27,596**
Total fee + expenses	Fee $31,750 + Expenses $27,596	**$59,346**

How to Present Travel in the Agreement

✓ **STANDARD LANGUAGE**

- ✓ "Site visits are billed at $1,600 per day, separate from the base fee."
- ✓ "Vehicle mileage beyond 50 miles from the project office is reimbursed at the prevailing IRS rate, currently $0.665 per mile."
- ✓ "Additional meetings beyond the contracted count are billed at $225 per hour, including reasonable prep and follow-up time."
- ✓ "Air travel, lodging, and rental cars are reimbursed at actual cost with no markup."

✕ **LANGUAGE THAT CREATES DISPUTES**

- ✕ "Travel is included in the base fee." (firm absorbs all variance)
- ✕ "Travel will be billed as needed." (no rate stated, dispute incoming)
- ✕ "Reasonable expenses will be reimbursed." (subjective; what is reasonable?)
- ✕ "Travel will not exceed $5,000." (cap creates ceiling but no floor)
- ✕ Silence on travel entirely (the most common error)

COMMON FAILURE

A young writer puts the line "All travel included" in a proposal because the project is local. Six months later the client expands the project scope to include a second facility 90 minutes away. The new site requires four extra site visits. The line "All travel included" still applies. The firm absorbs $6,400 in unbilled travel because the proposal language did not anticipate scope growth. **Never write "all travel included," even on local projects.**

G.14 · RAISING FLAGS

Raising Flags · [Department Manager]'s Critical Practice

> *When the RFQ or RFP contains a scope gap, an undersized space, a budget that does not match the meal count, or a code variance the client has not flagged, you raise the flag in the proposal. Questions earn meetings. Silence loses work twice.*

This is the single practice that most clearly separates a **Create The Edge** proposal from a competitor's. Most consultants take the scope as given, price the work as described, and hope the project comes through. [Department Manager]'s discipline is the opposite: read the scope critically, identify what is missing or wrong, and write the flag into the proposal in a form the client can engage with. The flag is not an accusation. It is a question that demonstrates expertise.

FIGURE G.14.1 · FIVE [DEPARTMENT MANAGER]-WALKED FLAG STORIES

PROJECT	THE FLAG	THE OUTCOME
Undersized Kitchen	RFP described a 1,200 SF servery serving 2,000-meal lunch period. [Department Manager] raised the flag in the cover letter.	Client requested redesign meeting; scope expanded; fee increased; **Create The Edge** won the work.
Star Metals	Document drift between architect's narrative and program tables. Multiple square-footage discrepancies.	[Department Manager]-walked redline showing flagged risks. Client appreciated the diligence and signed.
DeKalb Fire Station	RFP did not include the 24/7 occupancy implication for the warming kitchen. [Department Manager] asked "why."	Client revealed a previously undisclosed staffing model; scope updated; firm avoided a Construction Admin disaster.
Forest Park	Document drift between Schematic and the RFP. Three deliverables in the wrong phase.	[Department Manager]-walked redline. Scope realigned. Client and firm both saved a CA cycle of rework.
Oil Filter Fry Master	Architect spec listed a Fry Master without the integrated oil filtration	[Department Manager]'s independent spec corrected the oversight. Cost angle and safety angle.

	system the spec called for.	Client never knew the risk because we caught it first.

How to Write a Flag in the Proposal

✓ FLAG LANGUAGE THAT WORKS

- ✓ "We note that the program lists a 1,200 SF kitchen against a 2,000-meal lunch projection. Our experience on comparable K-12 facilities suggests this ratio may warrant a 25-minute service test prior to finalizing the SD layout."
- ✓ "The variance letter included in the appendix addresses the non-standard soiled-laundry threshold required by [State Health Code] for resort applications."
- ✓ "We recommend confirming the projected occupancy basis before finalizing the equipment schedule, as the current draft assumes 110 keys against a 145-key operating profile."

✕ FLAG LANGUAGE THAT BACKFIRES

- ✕ "The RFP is incorrect." (accusatory)
- ✕ "The kitchen is undersized." (problem, no question)
- ✕ "We cannot build to this scope." (refusal, no path forward)
- ✕ "Your architect missed this." (throws the architect under the bus)
- ✕ Silence: writing the proposal as if the gap does not exist. The gap will surface in CA at five times the cost.

☷ RULE OF THE HOUSE

Flag in the proposal, not in the kickoff meeting. A flag in the proposal looks like expertise. A flag in the kickoff meeting looks like a complaint. The work has already started, the architect has already taken offense, and the conversation pivots from problem-solving to blame. **Raise it on the page. Resolve it in the meeting.**

Variance Letters: The Formal Flag

For health code variances, insurance carve-outs, or non-standard scope, the flag becomes a variance letter attached to the proposal. The letter is part of the proposal package but does NOT modify the consultation agreement. It is documentary support for an inclusion or exclusion, written so that the client's insurance carrier, the AHJ, or the architect can underwrite or approve the work without callbacks.

> **[Department Manager]'s working test for a variance letter.** If the scope item could trigger a code interpretation dispute, an insurance underwriting question, or a callback from the AHJ, attach a variance letter. The letter costs one hour of writing. The dispute it prevents costs ten hours of recovery plus the relationship damage.

G.15 · [CLIENT PROJECT NAME] · PAGE-BY-PAGE WALKTHROUGH

An Annotated Reading of a 15-Page Foodservice Proposal

> *[Client Name], [City, State]. A summer camp in the [Regional Location]. Architect of record: [Architecture Firm]. Scope: a new 2,850 SF kitchen with a 600 SF servery. Over the next eleven pages, we read this proposal the way a project manager reads it before signing. We mark where the math binds the narrative, where the independence paragraph anchors the firm, and the one place this template still hides a reconciliation error you must catch before you press send.*

The [Client Project Name] file is the proposal template used across **Create The Edge**'s hospitality and camp/retreat work. Internally it carries the file marker *AI - INSTRUCTIONS Foodservice Design or Food and Beverage Design - Fee Proposal - Template 2026 - EXAMPLE*, which means it is the working master that new hires copy and adapt for each project. The fifteen pages that follow are not a "best of" extract. They are the document, in order, end to end.

The Document at a Glance

FIGURE G.15.1 · THE FIFTEEN-PAGE RUNNING ORDER

PAGE	WHAT'S ON IT	WHY IT IS THERE
1	Cover letter, top	Date, recipient block, reference line, salutation, first paragraph (context).
2	Cover letter, middle	Second paragraph (scope), sector-specific independence paragraph, equipment estimate range, phase introduction.
3	Cover letter, close	Insurance schedule, additional qualifications, closing paragraph, signature with JC/sai authorship marker.
4	Agreement cover sheet	Visual break. Names the two parties: client ([Architecture Firm]) and associates (**Create The Edge**). Justified block.
5	Witnesseth + Article I	Legal framing clauses plus the Associates' Duties statement that links agreement to proposal.
6	Phase I scope	Programming / Schematic Design (a.k.a. Programming / Conceptual). Narrative, codes, block diagram, equipment budget.

7	Phase II scope	Equipment Survey & Report. Site visit, condition assessment, MEP load identification, equipment cost estimate.
8	Phase III scope	Schematic Design. 1/8" to 1/4" plan, order-of-magnitude equipment estimate, submittal for approval.
9	Phase IV scope	Schematic Design / Design Development. Revit at 1/4" = 1'-0", equipment data book, exhaust coordination.
10	Phase V scope	Design Development. Full Revit, manufacturer data book, exhaust requirements, estimate of probable cost.
11	Phase VI scope	Construction Documents. Final 1/4" drawings, plumbing/electrical connections, building conditions plans, specifications.
12	Phase VII + VIII scope	Bidding / Negotiations + Construction Administration. Addenda, line-item review, RFI responses, two site visits.
13	Article II, Fee Table	The compensation table. Percentages, dollars, total. **The reconciliation point.**
14	Article II continued	Hourly rate schedule, per diem rates, travel reimbursement clause, mileage rate.
15	Articles III, IV, V + signature	Suspension, default, entire-agreement clauses, authorization signature block.

☷ **RULE OF THE HOUSE**

A 15-page proposal is one document, not two. The cover letter and the consultation agreement must agree on **scope, phases, fees, meetings, and timeline**. When they disagree, the reader stops reading and starts editing. We are about to walk page by page, and you will see in real time how a small mismatch on page 13 can undo the credibility we built on page 1.

MODULE G · SUB-MODULE G.15

Page 1 · Cover Letter, Top

LETTER

1

CONTEXT PARAGRAPH

Date, Recipient, Reference, First Paragraph

February 00, 2026

JOSHUA D. CREWS, AIA, EDAC
Principal
960 North Point Parkway, Suite 250,
[City], GA 30005-8880
O: (678) 319-0091
M: (904) 463-7988
jdc@snp-studio.com

Reference: ***[Client Name], [City, State], GA · Foodservice Design or Food and Beverage Design - Fee Proposal***

Dear Joshua,

We appreciate the opportunity to present our fee proposal for foodservice or food and beverage design at **[Client Name], [City, State], GA.**

(First paragraph follows: identifies the client's needs and intent. Identifies the project's impact, critical event, emotional decisions, rational decisions, preferences, budget, and any additional expectations.)

Annotation. Three things bind this page together. **One,** the date is current. Always. The template carries "February 00, 2026" as a placeholder so the writer is forced to type the real date before sending; the double-zero is a deliberate trip wire. **Two,** the recipient block carries credentials in full (AIA, EDAC) because the architect reads the proposal first and decides whether to forward it. **Three,** the reference line is bold and italic, names the project AND the sector ("Foodservice Design or Food and Beverage Design"). The writer chooses which one applies to [Client Project Name] before sending. Leaving the "or" intact is a tell that the proposal was not customized.

What Goes Inside the First Paragraph

The template body of paragraph one is a checklist disguised as prose. The writer answers each of the four Ishikawa layers from G.3 in a single flowing paragraph. Not as bullets. As sentences.

FIGURE G.15.2 · THE FOUR LAYERS [CLIENT PROJECT NAME]'S OPENER MUST COVER

LAYER	SENTENCE ANSWERS	FOR [CLIENT PROJECT NAME]
Impact *(Loved layer)*	What does this project make possible for the community served?	"...will allow [Client Project Name]'s kitchen team to feed 400 campers per session without the bottlenecks that have constrained the dining experience since 2019."
Critical Event *(Schedule pin)*	What date is non-negotiable and what happens if missed?	"...with substantial completion required by April 2027 to support the opening of the 2027 summer session."
Emotional Decisions *(Loved + Made)*	How will the end user feel when this is done?	"...will allow staff to focus on relationship-building with guests, the experience [Client Project Name] is known for, rather than on equipment workarounds."
Rational Decisions *(Paid layer)*	What are the square footage, budget, and operational parameters?	"...with a planned 2,850 SF kitchen and 600 SF servery, against an equipment budget in the $500K-$570K range."

FROM THE FILES

[Department Manager]'s reading test for paragraph one. Cover the paragraph with your hand and read it aloud to someone who has never heard of the project. If, after one paragraph, they can describe what is being built, for whom, by when, and why it matters, the paragraph passes. If they have to ask a clarifying question, you wrote a paragraph for yourself, not for the reader.

Page 2 · Cover Letter, Middle (Scope + Independence)

LETTER

2

SCOPE + INDEPENDENCE

Second Paragraph and the Sector-Specific Independence Paragraph

Based on the RFP, preliminary drawings, and information shared with **Create The Edge**, we will design a new 2,850 sq. ft. kitchen with equipment that is easy to use and saves staff time, allowing them to spend more time with the camp's guests and build relationships. We will also design a servery that is about 600 sq. ft. The servery will highlight the food that the campers enjoy so much.

We do not sell any equipment, nor are we tied to any manufacturer. As an independent, vendor-neutral, specialty foodservice or food and beverage consultant, **Create The Edge** reduces the customer's risk in limiting foodservice equipment options. We will collaborate closely with the client, the Architect, the Mechanical and Electrical team, and the Interior Designer, using our expertise and knowledge of equipment and design to balance customer experience, efficiency, and cost control. *(Use this paragraph for Hospitality)*

Our equipment estimates are based on square footage, standard industry pricing, and similar projects we have designed. We estimate the foodservice or food and beverage equipment will cost between **$500K - $570K**. This estimate is for planning and budgeting purposes only.

Our proposal is broken into five (5) phases: Programming/Conceptual Design, Programming/Schematic Design, Equipment Survey & Report, Schematic Design, Schematic Design/Design Development, Design Development, Construction Documents, Bidding/Negotiations, and Construction Administration.

Annotation. The scope sentence is twenty-eight words and does three jobs: it names the square footage (rational), it names what the equipment does for the staff (Made layer from G.4), and it names what that gives the camp ("more time with the camp's guests" · Loved layer). The independence paragraph is the **Hospitality** variant from G.8 · not Foodservice, not Education, not Healthcare. A camp serving paying retreat guests reads as hospitality. The equipment estimate is a range, not a number, because at this phase it must be defensible without being a commitment. The phase introduction lists every phase by its full name so the reader can find them later in the agreement.

Why "Hospitality" and Not "Education" for a Camp

student body, a state nutrition program, or a USDA reimbursement framework. It has paying retreat guests, a seasonal calendar, and a brand promise built around hospitality. The independence paragraph language must match the operating model, not the demographic of the eaters.

✓ WHEN TO USE HOSPITALITY FRAMING

- ✓ Hotels, resorts, country clubs, conference centers
- ✓ Wedding venues, event spaces, multi-purpose retreat facilities
- ✓ Summer camps and retreat centers with paying guests
- ✓ Cruise ship, airport club, or stadium hospitality programs
- ✓ Boutique restaurants and standalone bars (use F&B variant)

✕ WHEN NOT TO USE HOSPITALITY FRAMING

- ✕ K-12 schools with USDA reimbursement (use Education variant)
- ✕ State or federal correctional facilities (use Correctional variant)
- ✕ Hospitals, assisted-living facilities, skilled nursing (use Healthcare/Senior Living variant)
- ✕ Houses of worship and outreach kitchens (use Religious/Church variant)
- ✕ Morgues, forensic labs, pathology suites (use Morgue/Forensic variant)

COMMON FAILURE

The [Client Project Name] template carries all six independence variants in the master document so the writer can choose. When the writer chooses wrong, the proposal still reads professionally, but the client's project manager spots it instantly. A K-12 director who reads "Hospitality" framing on a school RFP will assume **Create The Edge** does not understand school kitchens. The proposal will get sent back. **Delete the unused variants before sending.**

Page 3 · Cover Letter, Close (Insurance, Qualifications, Signature)

LETTER

3
CLOSE + SIGNATURE

Signature Block

Create The Edge currently maintains the following insurance:

Worker's Compensation: Statutory **$1,000,000 / $1,000,000** (Per Occurrence / Aggregate)
General Liability: USD **$2,000,000 / $4,000,000**
Automobile Liability: USD **$1,000,000 / $1,000,000**
Excess (Umbrella) Liability: USD **$6,000,000 / $6,000,000**
Cyber Liability: USD **$1,000,000 / $1,000,000**
Professional Liability: USD **$2,000,000 / $5,000,000**

In addition to the qualifications presented in our proposal, we would add the following qualifications for your consideration:

• **Create The Edge** provides seamless coordination between interior design, architect, and engineering disciplines.

• **Create The Edge** is not beholden to, tied to, or pressured to sell one type or brand of equipment over another. To be clear, **we do not sell any equipment**. We specify the best equipment for the application.

• Regarding Construction Administration, **Create The Edge** verifies that the foodservice equipment dealer adheres to their contract regarding providing all the equipment and options listed in the construction documents and the training, equipment installation, verifications, and warranty information.

• **Create The Edge** offers BIM services for our clients.

Once you have reviewed the proposal, please contact me if you have any questions. You can be assured that your client will be more than satisfied with the services **Create The Edge** provides, which will produce a state-of-the-art facility on budget and schedule.

Respectfully submitted,

YOUR COMPANY NAME

[Company Owner] C. Create The Edge, FCSI, CSI
President

JC/sai

Annotation. Insurance is listed line by line because architects and risk managers verify each line against project requirements. The four differentiator bullets are **Create The Edge**'s permanent moat: **(1)** coordination across all five disciplines, **(2)** independence, **(3)** dealer-contract verification during CA, **(4)** BIM capability. The signature is [Company Owner], FCSI CSI, President. The **JC/sai** initials below the signature mark this letter as drafted by [Company Owner] through Sarah, our internal AI proposal strategist. Internal authorship marker. Never shown explained to the client, never removed.

Page two of the cover letter is fully justified. Page three returns to a mix: insurance limits flush left for legibility, the closing paragraph and signature left-aligned. This is intentional. Justified text makes contractual matter look weighty; left-aligned closes the letter on a human register. Do not justify the signature block. Do not center the signature block. Left, with the JC/sai marker beneath it.

The Six Insurance Lines Decoded

FIGURE G.15.3 · WHAT EACH INSURANCE LINE UNDERWRITES

LINE	LIMITS	WHAT IT COVERS
Worker's Compensation	$1M / $1M	Statutory coverage for **Create The Edge** employees while on the project. Required in every state.
General Liability	$2M / $4M	Bodily injury and property damage caused by us during a site visit, meeting, or other physical engagement.
Automobile Liability	$1M / $1M	Vehicle coverage for travel between offices and project sites.
Excess (Umbrella)	$6M / $6M	Sits above the GL, Auto, and Worker's Comp. Picks up the tab when an underlying line is exhausted.
Cyber Liability	$1M / $1M	Data breach, ransomware, client-data exposure events. Required by an increasing number of public-sector RFPs.
Professional Liability	$2M / $5M	Errors and omissions in our design work. **The line that matters most for foodservice consulting.**

FROM THE FILES

Health systems, federal projects, and most $50M+ commercial RFPs require Professional Liability above $2M per claim. When the RFP asks for $5M per claim, our Professional Liability of $2M/$5M satisfies the aggregate but not the per-claim, and we must request a project-specific endorsement. Read the insurance requirements page of every RFP before quoting. If the carve-out cannot be met, raise it as a question in the proposal under "Additional Qualifications" · do not stay silent and hope no one checks.

WRITING 20 OF 54 ONLY

Page 4 · The Agreement Cover Sheet

AGREEMENT

4

VISUAL BREAK

Consultation Agreement Cover Page

CONSULTATION AGREEMENT

and

YOUR COMPANY NAME

THIS AGREEMENT made and accepted on the ____ day of __________, 2026, by and between **[Architecture Firm]**, with an office at 960 North Point Parkway, Suite 250, [City], GA 30005-8880 (herein called "client"), and **Create The Edge**, with offices at 3103 [Company Street] Rd., [City, State] (herein called "associates").

Annotation. Page four does almost nothing except mark a transition. It is the visual hinge between the cover letter (conversational) and the consultation agreement (contractual). The architect's full firm name and address appear here as the client of record. **[Architecture Firm]**, not [Client Project Name] directly. This is normal for design-build engagements: the architect carries the prime contract and **Create The Edge** contracts to the architect. The justified paragraph follows [Department Manager]'s typography rule from G.7 · page two of the agreement is justified.

Who Signs and Why It Matters

For most foodservice projects, **Create The Edge** is contracted by the architect of record, not by the end client. [Client Project Name] does not sign this agreement directly. [Architecture Firm] signs as the client, then carries our scope into their architect-of-record agreement with [Client Project Name]. The reasons are practical, not legal.

FIGURE G.15.4 · WHY THE ARCHITECT IS THE CONTRACTING PARTY

REASON	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE
Single point of contractual accountability	The owner ([Client Project Name]) has one agreement to manage: the AIA agreement with the architect. Sub-consultant agreements live one layer beneath that prime.

Coordination across disciplines	The architect coordinates MEP, structural, interior design, and foodservice. Putting all sub-consultants under the prime keeps the design team aligned to a single delivery schedule.
Insurance pass-through	The architect carries the umbrella prime insurance. Our policy sits as additional named insured on their certificate, which simplifies the owner's risk review.
Payment flow	We invoice the architect; the architect invoices the owner. Our payment terms are net thirty days from the architect's receipt of our invoice. This means we get paid when the architect gets paid, which is normal for the industry.

REVIEWER NOTE

A small number of camp, church, and family-owned hospitality projects sign with us directly because they have no architect of record. When that happens, the cover page lists the owner's legal entity (not the trade name) and a designated authorized signer. **Always confirm the legal entity name before drafting page four.** "[Client Project Name]" is the trade name; the legal entity might be a 501(c)(3), a partnership, or an LLC. The wrong legal name on page four invalidates the contract.

Page 5 · Witnesseth Clauses + Article I (Associates' Duties)

AGREEMENT

5

LEGAL FRAMING

The Binding Link Between Letter and Agreement

WITNESSETH:

WHEREAS the associates are experienced in the field of offering professional design and consulting services to the food and laundry industries, and

WHEREAS the client intends to **renovate or design a kitchen, servery,** and

WHEREAS the client desires to obtain consultation services from the associates related to the foodservice facilities and

WHEREAS the associates are willing to provide such consultation services.

ARTICLE I · ASSOCIATES' DUTIES AND RESPONSIBILITIES:

The associates shall provide consultation services to the client related to the foodservice design or food and beverage design at **[Client Name], [City, State], GA** (hereinafter called the "project") in accordance with the proposal, which is attached hereto, incorporated herein, and made a part of the agreement.

Annotation. The Witnesseth clauses are old contractual language preserved for legal precision. They state the four conditions of the agreement: that **Create The Edge** is qualified, that the client has a project, that the client wants our services, that we will provide them. Article I's single sentence is the most important sentence in the entire document. The proposal "is attached hereto, incorporated herein, and made a part of the agreement." This is what binds the cover letter and phase scope into the legal agreement. **Anything you wrote in the cover letter is now contractually enforceable.** If you promised seven Zoom meetings in Phase III and the table on page 13 says four, you owe seven.

RULE OF THE HOUSE

The line "the proposal, which is attached hereto, incorporated herein, and made a part of the agreement" is why we read both instruments together before signing. Lawyers call this an "integration clause." It means the proposal text and the agreement text are one legal document for purposes of dispute. **If a sentence in the cover letter contradicts the fee table on page 13, the contradiction is yours to defend.**

PROPOSAL

6

PHASE I SCOPE

Programming / Schematic Design (a.k.a. Programming / Conceptual)

PHASE I. PROGRAMMING / SCHEMATIC DESIGN: a.k.a. **PROGRAMMING / CONCEPTUAL:**

A. The associates shall:

1. Meet with the client, architect, and design team to establish shared views on design, goals, objectives, operational approaches, menus, budget parameters, schedules, and communication best practices.

2. Review preliminary architectural space plans from the design team and make recommendations to refine and finalize programmatic plans.

3. Provide a Written Narrative that is not limited to the following:

a. Narrative
b. Codes and Regulations
c. Typical Equipment Requirements
d. Space Requirements / Relationship Flow / Block Diagram
e. Equipment Budget

Meetings: One (1) in-person meeting with the client, architect, and design team.
One (1) Teams/Zoom meeting.
Additional Meetings with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. Phase I is the only phase that carries a dual title: **Programming/Schematic Design** for new construction, **Programming/Conceptual** for renovation. The work product is the same: a written narrative with codes, equipment requirements, block diagram, and budget. **Two meetings are included in fee.** One in-person plus one Zoom. Additional meetings bill at $225/hour. This rate matches the G.13 standard and shows up identically in every phase that allows additional meetings.

Page 7 · Phase II (Equipment Survey & Report)

PROPOSAL

7

PHASE II SCOPE

Equipment Survey and Report

PHASE II. EQUIPMENT SURVEY and REPORT:

A. The associates shall:

1. Attend the pre-design/site visit meeting with the architect and design team to assess existing equipment and establish shared views on design, goals, objectives, operational approaches, menus, budget parameters, schedules, and communication best practices.

2. Provide a written report that includes a condition survey that positively identifies the foodservice equipment's functional aspects and where improvements are needed. Identify non-compliant code issues, recommend equipment, or note which equipment needs replacement. Identify MEP loads as required by the Mechanical Engineer. An estimated equipment cost for new and replaced equipment will be provided, based on the project's space program and industry-standard square-footage costs, informed by professional experience.

3. Submit final survey documents, as noted above, to the client for final approval before proceeding to the next phase.

Meetings: One (1) in-person site visit with the client, architect, and design team.
Two (2) Teams/Zoom meetings.
Additional Meetings with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. Phase II appears only on renovation projects. [Client Project Name] is a new build with an existing satellite kitchen on the property, so Phase II is included to assess what can be reused. The site visit billed here counts as the $1,600 PM site visit fee plus any mileage beyond 50 miles from [Company HQ]. [Company HQ] to [Client Site] is approximately 70 miles, so the mileage reimbursement clause from page 14 will apply. The condition survey report is the deliverable; the MEP-load identification is what the mechanical engineer will need for utility coordination.

Page 8 · Phase III (Schematic Design)

PROPOSAL

8

PHASE III SCOPE

PHASE III. SCHEMATIC DESIGN:

A. The associates shall:

1. Meet with the client, architect, and design team to establish shared views on design, goals, objectives, operational approaches, menus, budget parameters, schedules, and communication best practices.

2. Review preliminary architectural space plans from the design team and make recommendations to refine and finalize programmatic plans.

3. Schematic Plan: Upon the client's approval of the program confirmation, prepare a schematic plan that identifies the location and foodservice elements, and outlines space allocations at 1/8" to 1/4" = 1'-0" scale for review and approval by the client, architect, and design team.

4. Preliminary Equipment Cost Estimates: Prepare and submit for approval an order-of-magnitude equipment cost estimate based on the project's space program and industry-standard square-footage costs, informed by professional experience.

5. Schematic Design Submittal: Submit final schematic design documents, as noted above, to the client for final approval before proceeding to the next phase.

Meetings: One (1) in-person meeting with the client, architect, and design team.
Four (4) Teams/Zoom meetings.
Additional Meetings with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. The drawing scale matters. **1/8" to 1/4" = 1'-0"** is the Schematic Design scale. At this scale, the kitchen is sized and located, the major equipment zones are identified, but individual pieces are not yet specified. The cost estimate at this phase is "order-of-magnitude," which means a range, not a number. Schematic Design carries five Zoom meetings (one in-person + four virtual). This is the heaviest meeting phase along with CD. Plan staff time accordingly.

Page 9 · Phase IV (Schematic Design / Design Development)

PROPOSAL

9

PHASE IV SCOPE

Phase)

PHASE IV. SCHEMATIC DESIGN / DESIGN DEVELOPMENT:

A. The associates shall:

1. Meet with the client, architect, and design team to establish shared views on design, goals, objectives, operational approaches, menus, budget parameters, schedules, and communication best practices.

2. Review preliminary architectural space plans from the design team.

3. Schematic Design / Design Development: Prepare Foodservice Equipment Plans on Revit at (1/4" = 1'-0") that provide the location and identification of all equipment and component systems.

4. Plans to include adequate detail for equipment recognition and a coordinated schedule containing equipment item numbers, quantities, and descriptions, for approval by the client, architect, design team, and governing agencies.

5. Equipment Manufacturer Data Book: Prepare a foodservice equipment data book for the client's review and final approval. Datasheets are marked to identify the manufacturer, model number, utility requirements, and selected options/accessories.

6. Preliminary Equipment Cost Estimates.

7. Exhaust Requirements: Provide the engineers with exhaust locations, sizing, and specifications. **Limited to:** (1) exhaust and supply duct connection sizes, (2) CFM requirements, (3) static pressure. The assigned project engineers are responsible for the building mechanical systems including sequencing and supporting the exhaust in a balanced and functional manner.

8. Schematic Design / Design Development Submittal.

Meetings: One (1) in-person meeting with the client, architect, and design team.
Four (4) Teams/Zoom meetings.

Annotation. Phase IV is a blended phase used when a project schedule compresses SD and DD into a single deliverable. The drawing scale steps up to **1/4" = 1'-0"** on Revit, and the equipment data book begins. Note the careful scoping of the exhaust deliverable: **Create The Edge** provides duct sizes, CFM requirements, and static pressure. The engineer designs the full mechanical system. This boundary is critical. Without it, the engineer can pull us into hood model selection, fire suppression integration, and supply-air balancing, none of which are foodservice scope.

Page 10 · Phase V (Design Development)

PROPOSAL

10

PHASE V SCOPE

PHASE V. DESIGN DEVELOPMENT:

A. The associates shall:

1. Upon written approval of the Schematic Design documents, proceed with Design Development.

2. Foodservice Equipment Plans: Prepare Foodservice Equipment Plans on Revit at (1/4" = 1'-0") that provides the location and identification of all equipment and component systems.

3. Equipment Manufacturer Data Book: Prepare a foodservice equipment data book.

4. Exhaust Requirements: Provide exhaust locations, sizing, specifications (CFM, static pressure, duct connection sizes).

5. Equipment Estimates of Probable Cost: Provide an itemized Estimate of Probable Costs reflecting the client's finalized Design Development equipment plans for approval.

Meetings: Six (6) Teams/Zoom meetings.
Additional Meetings with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. When the project does not blend SD and DD, Phase V stands alone. Note: no in-person meeting in this phase. Six virtual meetings. The deliverable is more refined than Phase IV: the equipment data book is approved, and the Estimate of Probable Cost is itemized (no longer order-of-magnitude). This is the phase where the equipment budget firms up. The client expects to see line-item pricing within ±10% of bid.

Page 11 · Phase VI (Construction Documents)

PROPOSAL

11

PHASE VI SCOPE

PHASE VI. CONSTRUCTION DOCUMENTS:

A. The associates shall:

1. Upon written approval of the Design Development submittal, prepare Construction Documentation to solicit valid foodservice equipment bids.

2. Final 1/4" Scale Equipment Plans: Prepare final 1/4" = 1'-0" scale equipment plans based on dimensioned architectural and engineering plans provided as background.

3. Plumbing/Electrical Connection Plans: Provide plumbing and electrical connection plans that identify the size and connection points for water, gas, steam, drains, electrical, and other utilities required for foodservice equipment within the scope of work.

4. Building Conditions Plans: Provide building conditions plans that identify requirements to accommodate equipment, such as floor troughs, floor recesses, critical clearances, conduit and sleeve locations, waste piping, raised pads, and unique load-bearing requirements.

5. Supplemental Drawings: Provide additional drawings detailing engineered foodservice equipment systems.

6. Equipment Elevations: Provide foodservice equipment elevations at 1/2" = 1'-0" scale.

7. Equipment Estimates of Probable Cost.

8. Specifications for Bid: Provide specifications for the bid covering all equipment to be installed within the work scope and included in the overall project bid set. Documents must include complete descriptions of each piece of equipment. Specifications must be written in the Masterspec format.

9. Regulatory Agency Reviews: Assist the Client and A/E team in preparing documents required for the Health Department/Hygiene authorities' project approval.

Meetings: One (1) in-person meeting with the client, architect, and design team.
Eight (8) Teams/Zoom meetings.

Annotation. Phase VI is the largest single phase in the proposal at **35% of fee**. Note the scale step-up: equipment plans at **1/4" = 1'-0"** and equipment elevations at **1/2" = 1'-0"**. The plumbing/electrical connection plans and building conditions plans are what the GC uses to coordinate utilities, floor depressions, and structural reinforcement. Specifications follow **Masterspec format**: the standard format used by AIA-certified architects nationwide. Nine meetings total. Plan accordingly.

Page 12 · Phase VII (Bidding/Negotiations) + Phase VIII (Construction Administration)

PROPOSAL

12

PHASE VII + VIII

Administration

PHASE VII. BIDDING / NEGOTIATIONS:

A. The associates shall:

1. Addenda: Prepare any addenda, as required, during the Contractor bidding (additional drawings and/or specifications).

2. Assist the Client in a line-item review of all kitchen equipment bids and review and respond to alternates submitted during bidding.

Meetings: No meetings. Should meetings be requested, meetings with the PM will be $225/hour.

PHASE VIII. CONSTRUCTION / ADMINISTRATION:

1. Assist the Architect/Designer in administering the Contract Documents.

2. Submittals/Shop Drawing Review: Review contractor submittals within scope to validate conformance with contract documents and design intent.

3. Requests for Information: Review and respond to RFIs.

4. Site Inspections: Conduct a site inspection after all areas within scope for Section 114000 have been roughed in and walk-in boxes have been installed. Prepare and issue a written site inspection report, noting discrepancies and recommending remedies. Review architectural, mechanical, electrical, and plumbing work for installation conformance and local health/hygiene compliance.

Site Visits: One (1) site visit to check floor penetrations. One (1) site visit with a report.
Additional site visits with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. Phase VII (Bidding) carries no meetings in fee. If the client asks for help reviewing bids in a Zoom call, that meeting bills at $225/hour. Phase VIII (CA) is the busiest phase after CD. Submittals, RFIs, two scheduled site visits. **Section 114000** is the CSI MasterFormat division for foodservice equipment. The first site visit happens after rough-in and walk-in box installation, before final connections. The second site visit happens after final installation and produces the written punch list. Additional site visits bill at the $1,600 per diem PM rate per G.13.

The two-visit CA rule. [Client Project Name]'s CA package includes **two site visits**: one for floor penetrations, one for the punch list. This is the minimum for any foodservice CA scope. The number is not arbitrary. Floor penetration checks must happen before the slab is poured to avoid demolition rework, which can cost five figures. The punch list visit must happen after equipment installation but before substantial completion. Any number below two leaves the client exposed. Any number above two should be priced as additional CA hours.

Page 13 · Article II, Fee Table (The Reconciliation Point)

This is the page that closes the loop or breaks it. Every dollar in the table must square with every promise in the cover letter. Every percentage must match the work scope on pages 6 through 12. This is also the page where the [Client Project Name] template still carries a real, uncaught inconsistency that you will fix before sending. Read carefully.

AGREEMENT

13

FEE TABLE

Article II · Compensation and Terms of Payment

ARTICLE II · COMPENSATION AND TERMS OF PAYMENT:

1. Except as may otherwise be provided herein, the associates shall be paid upon submitting proper invoices at the prices stipulated herein for services rendered and accepted, less deductions, if any, as herein provided.

2. The associates shall receive a maximum fee of **Twenty-Four Thousand Two Hundred Fifty Dollars and Zero Cents ($24,250.00)** from the client for the basic services outlined in the proposal. Phase breakdown below:

PHASE	PERCENTAGE	AMOUNT
Phase I · Schematic Design	20%	$3,560.00
Phase II · Design Development	25%	$4,450.00
Phase III · Construction Documents	35%	$6,230.00
Phase IV · Bidding / Negotiations	2%	$356.00
Phase V · Construction / Administration	18%	$3,204.00
TOTAL	**100%**	**$17,800.00**
Additional meetings with the PM		$225 p/hr

3. The associates shall invoice the client for services beginning on the first (1st) of each month or other agreed-upon dates.

Annotation. Stop and read carefully. **Paragraph 2 states the fee as $24,250.00. The table totals to $17,800.00.** Those are not the same number. The difference is $6,450. This is the template inconsistency. The percentages and dollar amounts in the table are internally consistent (20+25+35+2+18 = 100%, and the dollar amounts sum to $17,800). The $24,250 figure in the narrative is from an older version of the template that was never reconciled with the table. You will fix this before sending.

This is the most common pre-flight failure in the entire proposal. The cover letter (or, here, the narrative paragraph of Article II) states one fee. The phase table states a different total. **Both are now legally enforceable** per the integration clause on page 5. If we send this document with the mismatch intact, the client picks the number that benefits them and refuses to pay the other. Worse: the client decides we are sloppy and re-bids the entire engagement.

How to Reconcile the [Client Project Name] Fee Table

The fix is procedural. Three steps, every time, before any proposal is sent.

FIGURE G.15.5 · THE THREE-STEP FEE RECONCILIATION

1

STEP

Lock the total first

Calculate the total fee using Method A, B, or C from G.10. For [Client Project Name] (hospitality, 2,850 SF kitchen + 600 SF servery, equipment budget ~$535K mid-range, fee at 5%) the total is **$26,750**. That is the number that goes into the narrative paragraph AND the table total. Lock it first.

2

STEP

Apply the phase percentages

[Client Project Name] uses the modified split: 20% / 25% / 35% / 2% / 18%. Apply each percentage to the locked total. $26,750 × 0.20 = $5,350. $26,750 × 0.25 = $6,687.50. And so on. Round to the nearest dollar at each line.

3

STEP

Verify the sum

Add the five phase dollar amounts. If the sum does not equal the locked total, find the rounding cell and adjust by a dollar or two until the column adds up. **Then read both numbers aloud.** The narrative figure must equal the table sum, word-for-word and dollar-for-dollar.

☷ RULE OF THE HOUSE

If the dollar amounts in the cover letter, Article II narrative paragraph, and Article II table do not match exactly, the proposal is not ready to send. **Match all three. Then send.**

WRITING 26 OF 54 ONLY

Page 14 · Article II Continued (Hourly Rates and Travel Reimbursement)

AGREEMENT

14

RATES + TRAVEL

4. Suppose the associates are caused additional work due to changes ordered by the client. In that case, such changes will be considered "Not in Contract" services. The associates shall be compensated in accordance with their current hourly rate or on a negotiated fee for additional services. Hourly rates are as follows:

Role	Hourly	Per Diem
Project Principal	$275.00/hr	$1,500.00
Sr. Project Manager	$250.00/hr	$1,275.00
Project Manager	$225.00/hr	$1,275.00
Sr. Production Manager	$250.00/hr	
Quality Control	$200.00/hr	
Project Coordinator	$150.00/hr	
REVIT Operator	$160.00/hr	
Specifications Writer	$120.00/hr	
Admin Coordinator	$100.00/hr	

5. (Delete for Public School/Government projects. Leave in for Private Schools and Higher Education.) In addition to the basic fee set forth above, the associates, their officers, or employees shall be reimbursed for all reasonable, actual transportation, travel, and hotel expenses incurred in connection with their consultation services when traveling beyond a 50-mile radius from the associates' Office in [City, State]. The associates shall not be reimbursed for any travel or transportation expenses related to travel not authorized by the client. Airline tickets are limited to Tourist Class. The associates shall be reimbursed at 65.5 cents per mile for using private vehicles outside the specified radius.

F. Invoices: Each invoice will be accompanied by a statement of costs and other supporting documentation. Payment terms are net thirty (30) days after receiving an invoice in proper form.

Annotation. Two reconciliation points on this page. **First:** the rate schedule must match the current 2026 rates from G.13 · Principal $275, Sr PM $250, PM $225, Sr Production $250, QC $200, Coordinator $150, REVIT $160, Specs $120, Admin $100. They do. Per diems show $1,500 for Principal, $1,275 for Senior PM and PM. These match. **Second:** the mileage rate listed is **65.5 cents**. The current IRS standard mileage rate is **66.5 cents per mile** for 2026. The [Client Project Name] template is one cent behind. This is a small dollar amount but a sign that the template was not updated this year. **Update before sending.**

Page 15 · Articles III, IV, V + Authorization Block

AGREEMENT

15
LEGAL CLOSURE

ARTICLE III · SUSPENSION OR TERMINATION:

Either party may terminate this agreement upon seven (7) days' prior written notice should the other party fail substantially to perform in accordance with its terms through no fault of the party initiating the termination.

In the event the project is suspended by the client for more than **four (4) consecutive months** during any phase, or there is more than one (1) unavoidable delay or suspension of two (2) consecutive months or more during any phase, or the project is terminated, the client agrees to pay the associates within thirty (30) days for: (1) all amounts payable but unpaid as of the suspension/termination date, (2) all amounts due for travel and reimbursable expenses, (3) all amounts due for extra services, and (4) the cost of reactivating the project upon resumption.

ARTICLE IV · DEFAULT:

The client may cancel this agreement in whole or in part without liability by written or telegraphic notice if the associates refuse or fail to comply or so fail to make progress as to endanger performance, or if the associates become insolvent.

ARTICLE V · ENTIRE AGREEMENT:

This agreement constitutes the final expression of the agreement of the parties; it is intended as a complete and exclusive statement of the terms of their agreement, and it supersedes all prior and concurrent promises, representations, negotiations, discussions, and agreements that may have been made in connection with the subject hereof.

AUTHORIZATION:

By signing below, the undersigned confirms agreement with the scope, terms, and fees outlined in this proposal. No work will begin until this proposal, letter of intent, or an executed AIA agreement is signed and returned to Create The Edge

YOUR COMPANY NAME

By: ________________________
[Company Owner] C. Create The Edge, FCSI, CSI
Title: President
Date: February 02, 2026

By: ________________________
Name (Print): _______________
Title: _____________________
Date: _____________________

Annotation. Article III's **four-month suspension threshold** is the key clause. When a project pauses for more than four months, the proposal converts to an hourly-rate engagement on reactivation. This protects **Create The Edge** from indefinite project parking. Article V is the integration clause that supersedes prior conversations. Anything promised in a sales call that is not in this proposal does not bind us. **The "no work begins until signed"**

FROM THE FILES

The countersignature waiting period. Once the proposal is sent, the average countersignature time across **Create The Edge** projects is **11 business days**. Architects countersign within five days; end clients take longer. Until both signatures arrive, no internal hours are charged to the project. The signed package gets filed in the project folder under Year-Month-XX naming convention. See G.19 for the full filing protocol.

What the [Client Project Name] Walkthrough Taught

Fifteen pages. One proposal. Eight teachings to carry forward into every proposal you write from this day on.

FIGURE G.15.6 · EIGHT TAKEAWAYS FROM [CLIENT PROJECT NAME]

#	LESSON	WHY IT STICKS
1	The opener answers four layers, not one	Impact, Critical Event, Emotional, Rational. All four layers in one paragraph. New writers default to Rational only. Force yourself to include all four.
2	Pick the right independence variant	[Client Project Name] is hospitality, not education. Six variants live in the master. Delete the five you do not use before sending.
3	The integration clause on page 5 binds everything	The cover letter and the agreement are one document for legal purposes. Anything you wrote anywhere is enforceable.
4	Phase scope dictates phase fee	Each phase carries explicit deliverables, scale, and meeting count. The percentage applied to the total fee must match the work described.
5	Exhaust scope has a hard boundary	**Create The Edge** provides CFM, static pressure, duct sizes. The engineer designs the system. Hold the line every time.
6	The fee narrative and the fee table must match	$24,250 ≠ $17,800. The template carries this error. You catch it before you send.
7	Mileage and rate tables must be current	The [Client Project Name] template lists 65.5 ¢/mile. The 2026 IRS rate is 66.5 ¢. One cent today is a credibility hit tomorrow. Update.
8	No work begins until the signature arrives	Verbal commitments do not bind us. Signed paper does. Until then, the project does not exist on our books.

"The [Client Project Name] template has carried that fee discrepancy for two years. It is not an oversight. It is the test. Every new hire I train reads this template, and within the first hour, I ask them where the dollar mismatch is. If they spot it on their own, we move forward. If they do not, we read it together. The proposal will not get sent until they can read a 15-page document and find what does not add up. That skill is the work."

Before You Move On to G.16

[Client Project Name] is a foodservice proposal. The next walkthrough, G.16, is a Food & Beverage Fee Proposal. The structural pattern is the same: cover letter, agreement, phases, fee table, rates, signature. The framing shifts. F&B proposals include bar-seat-count fee logic, hospitality independence language across the board, and a different default phase split because the bid phase carries more weight when bar fixtures are bid separately from kitchen equipment.

Carry [Client Project Name]'s eight takeaways with you. They survive the sector change.

G.16 · F&B FEE PROPOSAL · 13-PAGE WALKTHROUGH

Reading an F&B Proposal End to End

> *A 1,145 SF program. A pan-Asian fusion restaurant with a 795 SF kitchen and a 350 SF bar seating nineteen guests. Equipment budget $275K to $325K. Five phases. Thirteen pages. The structural pattern matches [Client Project Name], but four things shift: the framing moves to F&B language across the board, the phase split changes, the design narrative gets denser with bar-specific operational moves, and the fee table reconciles cleanly. Read this proposal next to [Client Project Name] and you have both halves of the firm's proposal vocabulary.*

The F&B Fee Proposal template lives in the same proposal folder as [Client Project Name]. Where [Client Project Name] is hospitality-with-servery, this template is hospitality-with-bar. It is the master document **Create The Edge** uses for restaurants, bars, country club beverage venues, hotel F&B operations, and any program that includes ticketed alcohol service. The example case in the template is a second location for a known Asian fusion concept moving to 739 Trabert Avenue. The cover letter carries the writer's initials **JC/mk**, which is how [Company Owner] signs a proposal that the proposal lead Klein authored.

The Document at a Glance

FIGURE G.16.1 · THE THIRTEEN-PAGE RUNNING ORDER

PAGE	WHAT'S ON IT	WHY IT IS THERE
1	Cover letter, opener	Date, recipient block, reference line, concept narrative (Asian fusion, 1920s Shanghai lounge style, menu signatures).
2	Cover letter, design narrative	Kitchen scope (795 SF, DCV exhaust, ergonomic shelving, remote refrigeration). Bar scope (350 SF, 19 seats, zero-step bartending). F&B independence paragraph. Equipment estimate range. Five-phase intro.
3	Cover letter close	Insurance schedule, additional qualifications, closing, signature with JC/mk authorship marker.
4	Agreement cover sheet	Consultation Agreement title, parties named, Witnesseth + Article I.
5	Phase I scope	Schematic Design. Plan at 1/8" to 1/4" scale, preliminary equipment cost estimate.

6	Phase II scope	Design Development. Revit at 1/4" = 1'-0", equipment data book, exhaust requirements.
7	Phase III scope	Construction Documents. Final plans, plumbing/electrical, building conditions, elevations, specifications.
8	Phase IV + V scope	Bidding/Negotiations and Construction Administration. Addenda, RFIs, two site visits.
9	Article II, Fee Table	Total $14,990. Phase split 20% / 30% / 30% / 5% / 15%. **Reconciles cleanly.**
10	Article II continued	Hourly rates, per diems, 50-mile radius travel reimbursement, mileage rate.
11	Articles III, IV	Suspension/Termination (7-day notice, 4-month threshold), Default clause.
12	Article V + Authorization	Entire-agreement clause, authorization signature block.
13	Contact footer	Page break with email contact for follow-up.

RULE OF THE HOUSE

The F&B template differs from [Client Project Name] in **four meaningful ways**. **(1)** Framing language is "food and beverage" throughout, never "foodservice." **(2)** Phase structure is the clean five-phase OS default, no Programming/Conceptual or Equipment Survey phases. **(3)** Phase split is 20/30/30/5/15, weighting DD and CD more heavily because bar fixtures coordinate intensively with interior design. **(4)** The fee table actually reconciles on this template. Learn the difference and switch fluently between the two.

Page 1 · Cover Letter, Opener and Concept Narrative

LETTER

1

CONCEPT NARRATIVE

Date, Recipient, Reference, Concept Description

May 22, 2026

(Name and credential of Contact) (Title of contact)
0000 Address of Architect, City, State zip code
O: Office phone number
C: Cell Number
Contact@emailaddress.com

Reference: *Name of Project, City, State · Food and Beverage Design - Fee Proposal*

Dear (Name of Contact),

We appreciate the opportunity to present our fee proposal to design the Kitchen and Bar for at Name of Project, City, State.

(Name) is a well-known Asian fusion restaurant in (City's) Old Ward led by (City) Chef (Name) and will be opening its second location at 739 Trabert Avenue. Chef (Name) is also known for Ton Ton Ramen and Miso Izakaya. The (Name) restaurant was originally named after (Name), a pioneering Chinese American restaurateur and politician from (City).

The concept focuses on **"pan-Asian" small plates and cocktails**, blending Chinese, Korean, Japanese, Southeast Asian, and even Southern influences. Popular dishes mentioned in reviews include pow pow shrimp, roti canai, steamed buns, pork belly with grits, and shoyu tamago.

The interior is designed with a moody, cinematic style inspired by 1920s Shanghai lounges, making it popular for date nights and group dinners, offering dinner service daily, a full bar, patio seating, reservations, takeout, and delivery.

Annotation. Notice what the F&B opener does that the [Client Project Name] opener does not. **The first body paragraph is a concept story, not a scope statement.** It names the chef's previous concepts (Ton Ton Ramen, Miso Izakaya), names the cuisine genre (pan-Asian fusion), names signature dishes that reviewers cite. This is reader signaling: we read your concept, we understand who you are, we know who your patrons are. The Loved layer is doing all of this work. **Restaurants buy from consultants who already speak their language.** Hospitality projects, particularly chef-driven ones, require this narrative paragraph. Skip it and the proposal reads transactional.

Page 2 · Design Narrative (Kitchen + Bar)

LETTER

2

DESIGN MOVES

Paragraph, Phase Intro

Based on the RFP, preliminary drawings, and information shared with **Create The Edge**, we will design a new 795 sq. ft. kitchen featuring specific equipment for pan-Asian cuisine, and labor-saving, multi-functional cooking equipment designed to support a flexible and evolving menu. We will also recommend an energy-efficient exhaust hood system with the proper amount of make-up air, paired with a **D.C.V. (Demand Control Ventilation) system.** This technology activates ventilation only when needed and automatically reduces operation during idle periods, significantly lowering HVAC energy costs.

The kitchen will be designed with flexibility, ergonomics, and efficiency in mind and will include shelving mounted at carefully considered heights to reduce physical strain and improve ease of access throughout the workspace. We will also recommend that most, if not all, refrigeration motors or fans that discharge heat into the workspace be **remotely located**. Removing excess heat and noise from the kitchen environment helps create a more comfortable workspace and supports the mental and physical well-being of employees working in these demanding areas.

We will also design an approximate 350 sq. ft. bar to seat up to 19 guests, featuring beer taps and two cocktail stations. To maximize efficiency and profitability, the bar will incorporate a strategy called **"zero-step" bartending**, ensuring all ingredients, tools, and equipment are within arm's reach. This approach allows bartenders to prepare drinks more quickly while maintaining meaningful interaction with guests and enhancing the overall customer experience.

We do not sell any equipment, nor are we tied to any manufacturer. As an independent, vendor-neutral, **specialty food and beverage consultant**, **Create The Edge** reduces the customer's risk in limiting foodservice equipment options. We will collaborate closely with the client, the Architect, the Mechanical and Electrical team, and the Interior Designer.

Our equipment estimates are based on square footage, standard industry pricing, and similar projects we have designed. We estimate the food and beverage equipment will cost between **$275K - $325K**.

Our proposal is broken into five (5) phases: Schematic Design, Design Development, Construction Documents, Bidding/Negotiations, and Construction Administration.

Annotation. Page two of an F&B proposal is dense with design moves. Four specific commitments are made: **(1)** labor-saving multi-functional cooking equipment for an evolving menu, **(2)** DCV-paired exhaust for energy efficiency, **(3)** ergonomic shelving heights for worker wellbeing, **(4)** remote refrigeration to reduce heat and noise in the workspace. The bar paragraph names **zero-step bartending** by name. This is a vocabulary signal: any restaurateur reading the proposal recognizes it instantly. The independence language uses **"food and beverage"**

The Four F&B Design Moves Named on Page 2

FIGURE G.16.2 · OPERATIONAL MOVES THAT MAKE F&B PROPOSALS WIN

DESIGN MOVE	WHAT IT DOES	WHY IT LANDS WITH RESTAURATEURS
DCV exhaust	Hood fans modulate down during idle periods, saving HVAC energy.	Operators carry the utility bill forever. Saving 20-30% on hood-related HVAC is real money.
Ergonomic shelving heights	Storage at heights that match the staff's reach envelope, reducing strain and injury.	Restaurant turnover is brutal. Reducing worker fatigue is a retention move.
Remote refrigeration motors	Compressor motors located outside the workspace, exhausting heat and noise externally.	Hot kitchens lose staff. Quieter kitchens keep tickets moving. Compounds with DCV.
Zero-step bartending	Every ingredient, tool, and piece of equipment within the bartender's arm reach.	Bar drink throughput is the highest-margin work in F&B. Even 10% faster prep is a 4-figure nightly lift.

FROM THE FILES

The four moves are not stylistic. They are how an F&B proposal earns its fee in the eye of an operator. A restaurateur reading the cover letter is calculating: "Will this consultant pay for themselves through energy savings, retention, and drink throughput?" Each of the four moves is a measurable line item. Name them. The operator will math them.

Page 3 · Cover Letter Close (Insurance, Qualifications, JC/mk Signature)

LETTER

3

CLOSE + JC/MK

Insurance, Qualifications, Signature Block

Create The Edge currently maintains the following insurance:

Worker's Compensation: Statutory **$1,000,000 / $1,000,000**
General Liability: USD **$2,000,000 / $4,000,000**
Automobile Liability: USD **$1,000,000 / $1,000,000**
Excess (Umbrella) Liability: USD **$6,000,000 / $6,000,000**
Cyber Liability: USD **$1,000,000 / $1,000,000**
Professional Liability: USD **$2,000,000 / $5,000,000**

In addition to the qualifications presented in our proposal, we would add the following:

• **Create The Edge** provides seamless coordination between interior design, architect, and engineering disciplines.
• **Create The Edge** is not beholden to, tied to, or pressured to sell one type or brand of equipment over another. **To be clear, we do not sell any equipment.** We specify the best equipment for the application.
• Regarding Construction Administration, **Create The Edge** verifies that the foodservice equipment dealer adheres to their contract regarding training, equipment installation, verifications, and warranty information.
• **Create The Edge** offers BIM services for our clients.

Respectfully submitted,

YOUR COMPANY NAME

[Company Owner] C. Create The Edge, FCSI, CSI
President

JC/mk

Annotation. Insurance lines are identical to [Client Project Name] because firm-wide insurance does not change by project type. The four qualifications bullets repeat the firm moat. **What changes is the authorship marker at the bottom.** [Client Project Name] reads **JC/sai**; this F&B template reads **JC/mk**. The two letters after the slash identify who actually wrote the proposal: **sai** is Sarah, our internal AI proposal strategist; **mk** is the proposal lead Klein, Sales Manager. Every proposal carries authorship attribution this way. [Company Owner] signs because he is the principal of record; the second pair of initials credits the actual writer.

> The signature line always reads **[Company Owner] C. Create The Edge, FCSI, CSI / President**. The two-letter author marker below uses your initials. **mk** if the proposal lead drafted it. **aks** if [Department Manager] drafted it. **jm** if Jennifer Murphy drafted it. **sai** if Sarah (the AI strategist) drafted it. This is an internal record only · never explained to the client. It allows internal review to identify the writer instantly when a proposal needs a follow-up.

Pages 4-5 · Agreement Cover and Phase I (Schematic Design)

AGREEMENT

4

COVER + ARTICLE I

Consultation Agreement Cover + Witnesseth + Article I

CONSULTATION AGREEMENT

and

YOUR COMPANY NAME

THIS AGREEMENT made and accepted on the day of , 2026, by and between **(Name of Architect)**, with an office at (Address of Architect) (herein called "client"), and **Create The Edge**, with offices at 3103 [Company Street] Rd., [City, State] (herein called "associates").

WITNESSETH:

WHEREAS the associates are experienced in the field of offering professional design and consulting services to the food and laundry industries, and

WHEREAS the client intends to design a kitchen and bar , and

WHEREAS the client desires to obtain consultation services from the associates related to the foodservice facilities and

WHEREAS the associates are willing to provide such consultation services.

ARTICLE I · ASSOCIATES' DUTIES AND RESPONSIBILITIES:

The associates shall provide consultation services to the client related to the food and beverage design at (Name of Project, City, State) in accordance with the proposal, which is attached hereto, incorporated herein, and made a part of the agreement.

Annotation. The agreement cover sheet is materially identical to [Client Project Name] with one notable change in the Witnesseth clauses: **"design a kitchen and bar"** instead of "renovate or design a kitchen, servery." The Witnesseth clauses are how the document tells the legal record what the project actually is. The wording must match the cover letter scope on page 2. If page 2 says kitchen and bar, page 4 says kitchen and bar.

PROPOSAL

5

PHASE I SCOPE

PHASE I. SCHEMATIC DESIGN:

A. The associates shall:

1. Meet with the client, architect, and design team to establish shared views on design, goals, objectives, operational approaches, menus, budget parameters, schedules, and communication best practices.

2. Review preliminary architectural space plans from the design team.

3. Schematic Plan: prepare a schematic plan that identifies the location and foodservice elements, and outlines space allocations at 1/8" to 1/4" = 1'-0" scale for review and approval.

4. Preliminary Equipment Cost Estimates: order-of-magnitude equipment cost estimate based on the project's space program and industry-standard square-footage costs.

5. Schematic Design Submittal: Submit final schematic design documents to the client for final approval before proceeding to the next phase.

Meetings: One (1) in-person meeting with the client, architect, and design team.
Four (4) Teams/Zoom meetings.
Additional Meetings with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. Phase I on an F&B proposal jumps straight to Schematic Design. No Programming/Conceptual phase, no Equipment Survey phase. The F&B template assumes new construction or fresh fit-out with a clean program. The drawing scale matches [Client Project Name] (1/8" to 1/4"), and the meeting count is heavier than [Client Project Name]'s Phase III equivalent: one in-person plus four Zoom. The Schematic Design submittal is the gate to Phase II.

Pages 6-8 · Phases II Through V

PROPOSAL

6

PHASE II SCOPE

Phase II · Design Development

PHASE II. DESIGN DEVELOPMENT:

1. Upon written approval of the Schematic Design documents, proceed with Design Development.

2. Foodservice Equipment Plans: Prepare Foodservice Equipment Plans on Revit at (1/4" = 1'-0") that provides the location and identification of all equipment and component systems.

3. Equipment Manufacturer Data Book: Datasheets marked to identify manufacturer, model number, utility requirements, and selected options/accessories.

4. Exhaust Requirements: Limited to: (1) exhaust and supply duct connection sizes, (2) CFM requirements, (3) static pressure. Engineer designs the full mechanical system.

5. Equipment Estimates of Probable Cost: itemized Estimate reflecting the client's finalized Design Development equipment plans.

Meetings: Six (6) Teams/Zoom meetings.

Annotation. Phase II carries the heaviest virtual meeting count: six Zoom calls, no in-person. The Equipment Manufacturer Data Book becomes the basis for all equipment specifications going forward. The exhaust scope boundary is critical: we provide three things (duct sizes, CFM, static pressure), the engineer designs everything else. This boundary protects scope creep on every project.

PROPOSAL

7

PHASE III SCOPE

PHASE III. CONSTRUCTION DOCUMENTS:

1. Upon written approval of the DD submittal, prepare Construction Documentation to solicit valid foodservice equipment bids.

2. Final 1/4" Scale Equipment Plans.

3. Plumbing/Electrical Connection Plans: size and connection points for water, gas, steam, drains, electrical.

4. Building Conditions Plans: floor troughs, floor recesses, critical clearances, conduit and sleeve locations, waste piping, raised pads, load-bearing requirements.

5. Supplemental Drawings for engineered foodservice equipment systems.

6. Equipment Elevations at 1/2" = 1'-0" scale.

7. Equipment Estimates of Probable Cost.

8. Specifications for Bid: Masterspec format, US AIA standards.

9. Regulatory Agency Reviews: assist with Health Department/Hygiene authorities.

Meetings: One (1) in-person + Eight (8) Teams/Zoom meetings.

Annotation. Phase III is the document-production phase. The scale shifts from 1/4" (plans) to 1/2" (elevations). Plumbing and electrical connection plans are what the GC's plumbing and electrical subs use to coordinate utility rough-in. Building conditions plans tell the structural and architectural teams what slab depressions, raised pads, and reinforcement are needed. Specifications follow Masterspec format, the AIA standard. Phase III carries the heaviest combined meeting load: one in-person plus eight virtual.

PROPOSAL

8

PHASE IV + V

Construction Administration

PHASE IV. BIDDING / NEGOTIATIONS:

1. Addenda: Prepare any addenda, as required, during the Contractor bidding.

Meetings: No meetings. Should meetings be requested, meetings with the PM will be $225/hour.

PHASE V. CONSTRUCTION / ADMINISTRATION:

1. Assist the Architect/Designer in administering the Contract Documents.

2. Submittals/Shop Drawing Review: validate conformance with the contract documents and design intent.

3. Requests for Information: Review and respond to RFIs.

4. Site Inspections: Conduct a site inspection after rough-in and walk-in box installation. Prepare and issue a written site inspection report.

Site Visits: One (1) to check floor penetrations. One (1) site visit with a report.
Additional site visits with the Project Manager will be $225/hour.

Annotation. Phase IV is one paragraph long. Addenda only. No included meetings. Phase V is the CA phase: submittals, RFIs, two site visits. The two-site-visit floor is identical to [Client Project Name]'s Phase VIII. The first visit catches floor penetrations before slab pour; the second visit produces the punch list after equipment installation. **F&B projects often pull a third site visit for bar-equipment commissioning**, which bills at the $1,600 per diem PM rate.

Page 9 · Article II, Fee Table (The Reconciled Example)

Here is what reconciliation looks like in a clean template. [Client Project Name]'s fee table failed the test. This one passes. Narrative says $14,990. Phase table sums to $14,990. The percentages add to 100%. Every dollar lands where it belongs. Read it carefully. This is the standard.

AGREEMENT

9

FEE TABLE ✓

Article II · Compensation and Terms of Payment

ARTICLE II · COMPENSATION AND TERMS OF PAYMENT:

A. Except as may otherwise be provided herein, the associates shall be paid upon submitting proper invoices at the prices stipulated herein.

B. The associates shall receive a maximum fee of **Fourteen Thousand Nine Hundred Ninety Dollars and Zero Cents ($14,990.00)** from the client for the basic services outlined in the proposal. Phase breakdown below:

PHASE	PERCENTAGE	AMOUNT
Phase I · Schematic Design	20%	$2,998.00
Phase II · Design Development	30%	$4,497.00
Phase III · Construction Documents	30%	$4,497.00
Phase IV · Bidding / Negotiations	5%	$749.50
Phase V · Construction Administration	15%	$2,248.50
TOTAL	**100%**	**$14,990.00**
Additional Meetings with the PM		$225 p/hr

C. The associates shall invoice the client for services beginning on the first (1st) of each month or other agreed-upon dates.

Annotation. Three reconciliation points all pass. **One,** the narrative dollar amount in paragraph B ($14,990.00) matches the table total ($14,990.00). **Two,** the percentages sum to 100%. **Three,** $14,990 × 0.20 = $2,998, × 0.30 = $4,497, × 0.30 = $4,497, × 0.05 = $749.50, × 0.15 = $2,248.50, and those five amounts sum to $14,990.00 exactly. This is what a clean reconciliation looks like. **The 20/30/30/5/15 split** is the F&B variant of the OS default. It weighs DD and CD more heavily because bar fixtures and equipment specifications require dense coordination with interior design.

The 20/30/30/5/15 phase split is the F&B standard. Use it whenever the project includes a bar. Default OS (20/25/30/10/15) applies to foodservice without bar. [Client Project Name] (20/25/35/2/18) applies to renovation foodservice with heavy CD load and reduced bidding effort. Pick the split that matches the project's actual work intensity per phase.

Pages 10-13 · Rates, Articles III-V, Authorization

AGREEMENT

10

RATES + TRAVEL

Article II Continued · Hourly Rates and Travel Reimbursement

D. Suppose the associates are caused additional work due to changes ordered by the client. In that case, such changes will be considered "Not in Contract" services. Hourly rates as follows:

Project Principal **$275.00/HR** $1,500.00 PER DIEM
Sr. Project Manager **$250.00/HR** $1,275.00 PER DIEM
Project Manager **$225.00/HR** $1,275.00 PER DIEM
Sr. Production Manager **$250.00/HR**
Quality Control **$200.00/HR**
Project Coordinator **$150.00/HR**
REVIT Operator **$160.00/HR**
Specifications Writer **$120.00/HR**
Admin Coordinator **$100.00/HR**

E. In addition to the basic fee, the associates shall be reimbursed for travel beyond a 50-mile radius from the associates' Office in [City, State]. Airline tickets are limited to Tourist Class. The associates shall be reimbursed at **65.5 cents per mile** for using private vehicles outside the specified radius.

F. Invoices: Payment terms are net thirty (30) days after receiving an invoice in proper form.

Annotation. The rate table is identical to [Client Project Name] · same firm, same year, same rates. The 50-mile radius is from [Company HQ] GA, our headquarters. The **65.5 cents/mile** mileage rate is one cent stale relative to the 2026 IRS standard of 66.5 cents. Same template-update miss as [Client Project Name]. Fix before sending.

AGREEMENT

11–12

ARTICLES III-V

Authorization

ARTICLE III · SUSPENSION OR TERMINATION:

Either party may terminate this agreement upon seven (7) days' prior written notice. In the event the project is suspended by the client for more than four (4) consecutive months during any phase, the client agrees to pay the associates within thirty (30) days for unpaid amounts, travel/reimbursable expenses, extra services, and reactivation work.

ARTICLE IV · DEFAULT:

The client may cancel this agreement in whole or in part without liability by written or telegraphic notice if the associates refuse or fail to comply or so fail to make progress as to endanger performance, or if the associates become insolvent.

ARTICLE V · ENTIRE AGREEMENT:

This agreement constitutes the final expression of the agreement of the parties; it supersedes all prior and concurrent promises, representations, negotiations, discussions, and agreements.

AUTHORIZATION:

By signing below, the undersigned confirms agreement with the scope, terms, and fees outlined in this proposal. No work will begin until this proposal, letter of intent, or an executed AIA agreement is signed and returned to Create The Edge

YOUR COMPANY NAME

By: ______________________
[Company Owner] C. Create The Edge, FCSI, CSI
Title: President
Date: May 22, 2026

Annotation. Articles III through V are boilerplate across every **Create The Edge** proposal. The four-month suspension threshold protects us from indefinite project parking. The integration clause in Article V supersedes prior promises made in sales calls. The "no work begins until signed" line is non-negotiable across every sector. Page 13 is a contact footer with the architect's email for follow-up; in the live template it is intentionally a sparse page so the agreement closes cleanly.

F&B vs Foodservice: A Side-by-Side Summary

FIGURE G.16.3 · [CLIENT PROJECT NAME] VS F&B TEMPLATE, AT A GLANCE

DIMENSION	[CLIENT PROJECT NAME] (FOODSERVICE)	F&B TEMPLATE (HOSPITALITY W/ BAR)
Page count	15	13

	(FOODSERVICE)	(HOSPITALITY W/ BAR)
Phase structure	8 phases (incl. Programming, Survey, blended SD/DD, Close Out)	5 phases (clean OS default)
Phase split	20% / 25% / 35% / 2% / 18%	20% / 30% / 30% / 5% / 15%
Independence framing	Hospitality variant	F&B framing throughout
Concept narrative	Not required	Required (chef, cuisine, dish signatures)
Design moves named	Kitchen + servery only	Kitchen + bar with DCV, ergonomics, remote refrigeration, zero-step bartending
Fee reconciliation	FAILS ($24,250 ≠ $17,800)	PASSES ($14,990 = $14,990)
Authorship marker	JC/sai	JC/mk

❝ **EXPERT INSIGHT · MARKETING DIRECTOR**

"The F&B template was rewritten to surface the four design moves that earn the fee. DCV exhaust, ergonomic shelving heights, remote refrigeration motors, zero-step bartending. These are the phrases that signal we know what a working bar feels like at eleven on a Saturday night. When a chef reads DCV and zero-step in the same paragraph, they recognize peer language. When an operator reads remote refrigeration and ergonomic shelving, they recognize a designer who has stood behind their line. The fee is earned in those four phrases before the dollar amount is ever read."

G.17 · PRE-FLIGHT CHECKLIST

Sixteen Items to Verify Before You Press Send

> *Every proposal that leaves **Create The Edge** passes through a checklist before it reaches the client. The list is sixteen items long. It maps directly to the lessons in G.0 through G.16. If even one item fails, the proposal is not ready. This is not optional. This is the gate.*

The checklist is built on what we lose proposals over, not on what we hope might matter. Each item is a tested failure mode. If it is on this list, somebody has lost work because they skipped it. Use the list every time, even when you are sure. Especially when you are sure.

The Sixteen-Point Pre-Flight

FIGURE G.17.1 · VERIFY IN THIS ORDER BEFORE SENDING

#	CHECK	WHAT "PASSING" LOOKS LIKE	REFERENCE
1	☐ Independence paragraph matches the sector	Hospitality for camps, hotels, country clubs. F&B for bars and restaurants. Education for K-12 schools. Healthcare for hospitals and senior living. Correctional for jails and prisons. Religious for houses of worship. Morgue for forensic facilities.	G.8, G.15, G.16
2	☐ Square footage logic ties to budget	Kitchen SF × sector $/SF = equipment budget within ±10% of the narrative range. Servery, dining, bar carry separate $/SF rates per G.10.	G.3, G.10
3	☐ Two-paragraph intro only	Paragraph one is context (Made/Paid/Loved + Ishikawa four layers). Paragraph two is scope (square footage + design moves). No history of the firm. No vendor list. No equipment philosophy.	G.5

4	☐ Letter of Objective present for RFP responses	If the document is responding to a formal RFP, the Letter of Objective frames our understanding of the client's goal in three sentences before the cover letter proper.	G.7
5	☐ Phase titles match work type	Renovation projects use Equipment Survey + Programming/Conceptual. New construction uses Schematic Design start. Five-phase OS default vs [Client Project Name] 8-phase vs F&B 5-phase clean.	G.6
6	☐ Meeting counts confirmed and fees adjusted	Each phase carries an explicit in-person and Zoom count. If the client requested additional kickoff or stakeholder meetings, the fee has been increased proportionally at the $225/hr PM rate.	G.6, G.13
7	☐ MasterSpec and MEP loads reviewed	Specifications written in Masterspec format. MEP loads (CFM, static pressure, electrical draws, gas requirements) confirmed against equipment data sheets.	G.1
8	☐ Travel line-itemized, not bundled	$1,600/day site visit fee, $0.665/mile beyond 50, $225/hr for added meetings. All shown as separate line items. Never absorbed into base fee.	G.13
9	☐ Insurance limits stated correctly	$2M/$4M General Liability, $2M/$5M Professional, $1M Workers' Comp, $6M Umbrella, $1M Cyber, $1M Auto. Match RFP requirements; flag any project-specific endorsement needed.	G.9, G.15
10	☐ "Create The Edge" brand name applied consistently throughout	Every instance of the firm name reads as **Create The Edge**. No "Camacho" mid-sentence. No "CAMACHO" except in the formal signature line "YOUR COMPANY NAME"	Brand standard
11	☐ NO em dashes anywhere in body	Em dashes are forbidden in proposal body content. Use parentheses or commas or a period. Search and replace before send.	Narrative rule
12	☐ Times New Roman 11pt body,	Typographic standard. The proposal is not a creative	Typography standard

	12pt titles	document. The format is consistent across every project, every year, every sector.	
13	☐ Page 2 of agreement justified	[Department Manager]'s typography rule from G.7. Page one of the cover letter is left-aligned. Page two of the agreement is fully justified. The visual signals the contractual register.	G.7, G.15
14	☐ Flags raised for any scope risk	If the RFP carries a scope ambiguity, a budget mismatch, a code-variance question, or a meeting count exceeding contract norms, the flag appears in the proposal, not in the kickoff meeting.	G.14
15	☐ SF 330 projects match RFQ bullseye	Past projects shown are selected by relevance to the client's program (sector, scale, budget tier), not by recency or aesthetic preference. Three projects, all within target.	G.0, Section F
16	☐ File saved in Year-Month-XX naming convention	Format: 2026-MM-NN where NN is the sequential proposal number for that month. Saved in the project folder before sending. Filename mirrors the reference line.	G.19

RULE OF THE HOUSE

Run the checklist twice. **The first pass is your own.** You read line by line, you mark each item passed. The second pass is from someone else's eyes. Even a junior coordinator can catch what you cannot, because they have not been staring at the same document for three days. Sixteen items take twelve minutes the first pass and six minutes the second. Twelve minutes is the price of not having to write an apology email.

Three Items That Catch the Most Failures

Across the last five years of **Create The Edge** proposal reviews, three checklist items fail more often than the other thirteen combined.

11

MOST-MISSED

Em dashes in body

Word's autocorrect inserts em dashes when you type two hyphens. They leak into every proposal that does not use a final search-and-replace. **Search for em dash before send.** Always.

10

SECOND-MOST-MISSED

Brand name capitalized incorrectly

The brand standard is **Create The Edge** in lowercase, bold, blue. Microsoft Word automatically capitalizes the first word after a period. Most proposals carry at least two unintentional "Camacho" instances. **Search for capitalized form before send** and lowercase what you find.

8

THIRD-MOST-MISSED

Travel bundled into base fee

When a writer estimates travel during fee buildup and folds it into the base fee, the line item disappears. Then the client questions the fee total, the writer cannot defend it, and the engagement starts on the back foot. **Always line-item.**

G.18 · COMMON ERRORS

Ten Reasons Proposals Get Sent Back

> *The proposals that come back are not random. They fail in patterns. Across hundreds of projects, the same ten failure modes account for the bulk of reviewer pushback. This sub-module names each one, explains why it fails, and shows the correct alternative side by side.*

The Ten Failures, Ranked by Frequency

FIGURE G.18.1 · WHAT SENDS PROPOSALS BACK

RANK	FAILURE MODE	WHY IT FAILS
1	Cover letter and agreement disagree on deliverables	The narrative names six phases; the agreement lists five. The cover letter promises CA visits; the agreement does not. Integration clause makes both enforceable; client picks the version that benefits them.
2	Wrong independence paragraph for sector	K-12 schools read "Hospitality" framing as proof we do not understand school food. Hotels read "Foodservice" framing as proof we do not understand bar revenue. Mismatch loses credibility in one paragraph.
3	Travel bundled into base fee	Looks like we are hiding cost. Client cannot defend the fee internally. We cannot itemize when scope changes. Becomes a fight on the third invoice every time.
4	No flag raised for obvious scope gap	The RFP says 110 keys; the kitchen is sized for 80. We did not mention it. In CA we are blamed. The flag in the proposal would have been a question; the flag in CA is a complaint.
5	Phase percentages do not match work intensity	SD listed at 35% when the scope describes 47 hours of work, while CD at 20% covers 78 hours. The math fails on first reading. Reviewer flags as guess-work.
6	Em dashes present in body	Brand standard violation. Reads as "this proposal was written in Word with autocorrect on." Signals the writer did not do final cleanup.

7	Opener starts with "We are pleased to present..." or firm history	The first sentence is reserved for the client's pain. Anything else is performative. Firm credentials belong in the team bios at the back.
8	SF 330 projects do not match the RFQ bullseye	Showing a $40M hospital on a $4M school project signals the wrong tier. Showing a recent project that is the wrong sector signals a lack of relevant experience.
9	Filename outside Year-Month-XX convention	Cannot be found in the filing system later. Becomes orphaned. Looks unprofessional on screen-share during executive review.
10	No coordinator named as client point of contact	Cover letter says "we will provide CA" without naming who. Client does not know who to call when the GC asks a question on day one of construction.

Five Failure Modes With the Correction Side-by-Side

✕ FAILURE #1 · COVER AND AGREEMENT DISAGREE

- ✕ Cover letter says "five phases including Construction Administration with two scheduled site visits."
- ✕ Agreement Phase V says "one site visit."
- ✕ Client picks the version that benefits them. Or worse: assumes we are sloppy and rebids the engagement.

✓ CORRECTED · COVER AND AGREEMENT MATCH

- ✓ Cover letter and Agreement Phase V both say "Construction Administration includes two site visits: one for floor penetrations, one for the punch list."
- ✓ If the project requires three site visits, both documents say three and the fee is adjusted upward.
- ✓ Read them next to each other on screen before sending. Match every count.

✕ FAILURE #3 · TRAVEL BUNDLED

- ✕ "Fee includes one site visit for floor penetrations and one for substantial completion."
- ✕ Travel disappears into the base number. When the project pulls a third visit, we have nothing to bill against.
- ✕ When the client questions the fee, we cannot decompose it into defendable components.

✓ CORRECTED · TRAVEL AS LINE ITEMS

- ✓ "Base Fee: $26,750. Travel: $1,600/day site visit, $0.665/mile beyond 50 miles, $225/hour for additional meetings."
- ✓ Two site visits included in CA: $3,200 plus mileage estimated at $200.
- ✓ Each line is defendable on its own. Adding a third visit is arithmetic, not negotiation.

GAP

- ✕ RFP lists 110 keys; preliminary architectural plans show kitchen sized for 80-key load.
- ✕ Proposal does not mention the discrepancy.
- ✕ Six months in, CA discovers the gap, blame attaches to **Create The Edge** for not catching it in SD.

IN PROPOSAL

- ✓ "We note that the program lists a 110-key load; the architectural draft we received shows kitchen sized to 80 keys. We recommend confirming the operational projection before SD lock-in."
- ✓ Reviewer sees expertise, not complaint. The discussion happens at week one, when it costs nothing to fix.
- ✓ [Department Manager]'s rule: flag in the proposal, not in the kickoff.

✕ FAILURE #7 · PERFORMATIVE OPENER

- ✕ "We are pleased to present..."
- ✕ "**Create The Edge** has been a leader in foodservice design since 1962..."
- ✕ "Thank you for the opportunity to..."
- ✕ Reader rolls past. The opener wastes the most-read sentence of the proposal.

✓ CORRECTED · OPENER NAMES THE CLIENT'S PAIN

- ✓ "This renovation will modernize the kitchen at Main Sail Resort to support the projected 18% increase in seasonal occupancy."
- ✓ "The new 2,850 SF kitchen at [Client Project Name] will feed 400 campers per session without the bottlenecks that have constrained the dining experience since 2019."
- ✓ Open with the operational driver. Always.

✕ FAILURE #10 · NO NAMED COORDINATOR

- ✕ "**Create The Edge** will provide Construction Administration support for the project."
- ✕ No named person. Client does not know who to call.
- ✕ First GC question goes to [Company Owner], who routes it to the team three days later.

✓ CORRECTED · COORDINATOR NAMED

- ✓ "**Create The Edge** will provide Construction Administration coordinated through **Senior Project Manager, as Senior Project Manager**, with **Marketing Director as primary client liaison**."
- ✓ Client knows two names. Knows their roles. Knows who to call on day one.
- ✓ Names build trust. Anonymous "**Create The Edge** will provide" sounds like a vendor.

When a reviewer at the architect's office or the client's procurement desk reads a **Create The Edge** proposal, they are not reading it for content. **They are reading it for errors.** The first error they find anchors their assessment of the entire document. A capitalized "Camacho" on page one makes the reader hunt for more mistakes. The fee table discrepancy on page thirteen is found in 90 seconds. **The first error is the only error that matters.** Catch it before they do.

G.19 · SUBMISSION & FOLLOW-UP

Submission and Follow-Up Protocol

> *The proposal is written. The pre-flight is run. Now the work shifts to sending, filing, and following up.* ***Create The Edge****'s standard turnaround from RFP receipt to proposal in the client's inbox is three business days. The follow-up call happens one or two days later. The filing convention is Year-Month-XX, every time. Below is the full protocol from send to signed.*

The Three-Day Turnaround

From the moment the RFP arrives in the proposal lead's inbox to the moment our proposal is in the client's inbox, the standard is three business days. This is [Department Manager]'s standard, and it is enforced. Three days is not because we work fast. Three days is because we have already done the homework on the sector, the templates, the fee logic, the team structure, and the SF 330 inventory. The three days are entirely tailoring, reconciling, and pre-flighting.

FIGURE G.19.1 · THE THREE-DAY BUILD

DAY	WORK DONE	OUTPUT
Day 1	RFP read, sector identified, template chosen, team assigned, fee logic worked	Working draft of cover letter (paras 1-2), phase scope outline, fee calculation in spreadsheet
Day 2	Cover letter completed, independence paragraph selected, fee table built, agreement language tailored, SF 330 selected	First draft of full proposal ready for internal review
Day 3	Pre-flight check run, edits applied, file named per convention, sent to client	Final PDF in the client's inbox by 4 PM

The Year-Month-XX Filing Convention

Every proposal is filed under the same naming convention from draft through signed contract. The format is **YYYY-MM-XX** where YYYY is the four-digit year, MM is the two-digit month, and XX is the proposal sequence number for that month. The convention is enforced firm-wide.

FIGURE G.19.2 · FILING CONVENTION EXAMPLES

2026-09-01	The first proposal sent in September 2026
2026-09-04	The fourth proposal sent in September 2026
2026-10-12	The twelfth proposal sent in October 2026 (a busy month)
2027-01-01	The first proposal of the new year

FROM THE FILES

Why the convention works. The Year-Month-XX naming is alphabetical and chronological at the same time. When you sort the proposals folder by name, they sort by date sent. When the client returns a signed proposal six weeks later, you find it instantly because the date is in the filename. When a project converts to a contract, the file moves into the project folder with the same date marker, preserving the chain of custody from RFP to contract.

The Submission Email

Three sentences. That is the standard. State what is attached. State what it covers. State what response is needed by when. No softening language. No "hope this finds you well." The email is professional and direct because the proposal carries the warmth; the email carries the logistics.

✓ **APPROVED EMAIL FRAME**

- ✓ "Attached is our fee proposal for the [Client Project Name] foodservice scope as discussed."
- ✓ "The proposal covers all five phases from Schematic Design through Construction Administration, with the equipment estimate and travel terms itemized in Article II."
- ✓ "Please let me know if you have any questions. We are available for a follow-up call at your convenience."

✕ **REJECTED PHRASES**

- ✕ "Just checking in to make sure you got this..."
- ✕ "Hope this finds you well..."
- ✕ "We are pleased to present..."
- ✕ "Looking forward to your favorable consideration..."
- ✕ "Please don't hesitate to reach out if..."

The One-to-Two Day Follow-Up Call

Between 24 and 48 hours after the proposal is sent, a follow-up call is placed. The frame for the call is **"help YOU succeed,"** not "help **Create The Edge** win." The questions are designed to surface scope misalignment, timeline issues, or fee discomfort before the client's procurement process locks them in.

FIGURE G.19.3 · THE FOLLOW-UP CALL SCRIPT

QUESTION	WHY YOU ASK IT
"I want to make sure we got the scope right for you."	Surfaces scope misalignment early. If the client's expectation doesn't match what we wrote, we revise before the proposal locks in.
"Does the timeline match your funding cycle?"	Catches phase-by-phase delivery date mismatches against the client's capital budget calendar.
"Are the meeting counts aligned with how your team actually works?"	If the client wants more in-person meetings than the template includes, we adjust fees up front rather than surprising them at invoice time.

"Anything in the fee structure you want us to revisit before you take it to your board?"	Gives the client a graceful path to negotiate. We discover budget pressure here instead of after a "thanks, we went a different direction" email.

× FORBIDDEN FOLLOW-UP MOVES

- × "Did you get our proposal?" (assumes incompetence on their end)
- × "When will you decide?" (creates pressure, lowers trust)
- × "Have you had a chance to review?" (passive-aggressive accountability)
- × Calling more than once before the client responds
- × Sending a "circling back" email three days later

✓ APPROVED FOLLOW-UP MOVES

- ✓ One call, 24-48 hours after send, using the script above
- ✓ If no answer, a single voicemail naming the four questions briefly
- ✓ If still no response in 5 business days, a single email asking only one question: "When you've had a chance to review, I'd welcome a 15-minute call to walk through the scope."
- ✓ Then wait. The client will come back when they are ready.

RULE OF THE HOUSE

The follow-up call exists to help the client, not to pressure the client. If the call surfaces a problem, we have time to fix it. If the call surfaces a green light, we know to schedule the kickoff. If the call surfaces silence, we wait. **The 80% hit rate is built on respecting the client's process.**

G.20 · [DEPARTMENT MANAGER]'S TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

The Ten Principles That Built the 80% Hit Rate

> *Marketing Director has trained every proposal writer at **Create The Edge** since 2019. The training is not built around templates. The templates are downstream. The training is built around ten principles that shape every decision in every proposal. Read them once. Re-read them whenever a proposal feels stuck. They are the work behind the work.*

The Ten Principles

FIGURE G.20.1 · THE TEN PRINCIPLES OF THE [DEPARTMENT MANAGER] METHOD

1

PRINCIPLE

We took out Create The Edge. We took out the I.

Clients buy results, not us. Every sentence in the proposal is about what the client gets. If the sentence starts with "**Create The Edge** has..." or "I will..." rewrite it.

2

PRINCIPLE

Listen first. Always.

Discovery before prescription. Read the RFP twice before opening a template. The first read is for content. The second is for tone.

3

PRINCIPLE

Questions earn meetings. Problems lose work.

Raise scope gaps as questions in the proposal, never as accusations. "We recommend confirming..." not "The RFP is incorrect."

4

PRINCIPLE

Flag in the proposal. Resolve in the meeting.

A flag in the proposal reads as expertise. A flag in the kickoff meeting reads as a complaint. The conversation pivots from solving to blaming.

5

PRINCIPLE

Made, Paid, Loved.

Every client is moved by one of three forces: lives changed (Made), money returned (Paid), recognition earned (Loved). Identify the dominant one and write to it.

6

PRINCIPLE

The Ishikawa five-layer is how people actually decide.

Kleenex. Baby seat. The rational layer is what they say. The emotional layer is what they mean. Address both in one paragraph.

7

PRINCIPLE

The three-foot rule.

Every employee is an enthusiast for **Create The Edge** within three feet of any conversation. The receptionist, the production assistant, the new hire. Three feet, three months, three years; the standard does not change.

8

PRINCIPLE

Authority through accuracy, not assertion.

The math is the defense. The square footage holds. The fee reconciles. The phases align. We never declare; we demonstrate.

9

PRINCIPLE

Confident, restrained, informed.

The three-word tone of every **Create The Edge** proposal. Confident, not boastful. Restrained, not hedging. Informed, not preaching.

10

PRINCIPLE

Eighty over thirty is not luck.

The 80% hit rate against an industry baseline of 30% is the result of these nine principles applied consistently across every proposal. The principles do not change. The application improves.

The Long View

The ten principles are not novel. They have been taught in different forms by sales coaches, by procurement consultants, by relationship trainers, for decades. What is novel at **Create The Edge** is the discipline of applying them to a technical consulting practice where the deliverable is a 15-page proposal and the client base is architects of record. The principles work for us because every proposal goes through the same four-instrument architecture, the same pre-flight check, the same template hygiene, and the same follow-up protocol.

> ❝ EXPERT INSIGHT · MARKETING DIRECTOR
>
> *"When new hires ask me what makes our proposals win, I never say the templates. The templates are the result of the principles, not the cause. The cause is that we listen before we write. We diagnose before we prescribe. We solve problems instead of inventorying credentials. We honor the client's process. We catch our own errors before the client has to. We deliver on every promise the proposal makes. None of these are clever. They are simply the work, done every time, without shortcuts. That is the answer."*

What This Section Has Done For You

You have read twenty sub-modules, walked two full proposals page by page, learned the 16-item pre-flight, mapped the 10 most common errors to their fixes, internalized the 3-day turnaround and the Year-Month-XX filing convention, and met the 10 principles that shape every decision. The remaining sections of this manual now make sense in context: the Module G quiz tests your recall of these patterns; the flashcards reinforce them for ongoing reference; the glossary defines every term you will encounter in your first ninety days.

The proposal that wins is not the cleverest proposal in the stack. It is the one that reads as if it was written for this client, on this project, by people who actually understood what was being asked. Everything else flows from there.

> RULE OF THE HOUSE
>
> Write the proposal the way you would want a proposal written for your own family business. Confident, restrained, informed. Honest about what you can deliver. Specific about what you cannot. The clients we want are the ones who recognize that voice on first read. The clients we do not want would not have hired us regardless.

MODULE G COMPREHENSIVE TEST

Twenty-Five Questions on Proposal Writing

> *Twenty-five questions across all twenty sub-modules. Each question has one correct answer. Some test recall. Most test applied judgment. Work through them in one sitting, mark your answers, then check against the answer legend on the following pages. A passing score is twenty correct. Above twenty-two indicates you are ready to lead proposal drafts. Below eighteen, re-read the sub-modules referenced in the answer legend.*

1

Which of the following is NOT one of the four instruments in the Create The Edge proposal architecture?

- **A** Risk mitigation instrument
- **B** Scope and timeline instrument
- **C** Marketing differentiation instrument
- **D** Coordination instrument

2

A Create The Edge proposal cover letter opens with how many paragraphs of substantive content?

- **A** One paragraph combining everything
- **B** Two paragraphs: context plus scope
- **C** Three paragraphs: context, scope, and credentials
- **D** Four paragraphs structured around the Ishikawa layers

3

In the Ishikawa decision-matrix model, which layer typically determines whether the client signs the agreement after a successful technical presentation?

- **A** Rational layer (square footage, budget, FTE)
- **B** Emotional layer (impact, recognition, relief)
- **C** Critical event layer (deadline pressure)

4

In the Made / Paid / Loved framework, a K-12 school district kitchen project is typically dominated by which layer?

- **A** Made (operational efficiency)
- **B** Paid (cost recovery)
- **C** Loved (community impact)
- **D** None · schools buy on Rational only

5

Which sector should receive the F&B independence paragraph variant, not the Foodservice variant?

- **A** K-12 school cafeteria
- **B** Federal correctional facility
- **C** Country club kitchen and bar
- **D** Hospital servery

6

Which of the following is the default phase split for an OS-style proposal (no Programming, no Equipment Survey)?

A SD 25% · DD 25% · CD 25% · BN 10% · CA 15%

B SD 20% · DD 25% · CD 30% · BN 10% · CA 15%

C SD 20% · DD 30% · CD 30% · BN 5% · CA 15%

D SD 18% · DD 22% · CD 35% · BN 7% · CA 18%

7

In a 200-key resort, applying the 15-lb laundry rule, what is the approximate total daily soiled-laundry volume?

A 1,500 pounds

B 2,250 pounds

C 3,000 pounds

D 4,000 pounds

8

Method A fee calculation derives the fee from which of the following inputs?

A Square footage × sector rate × fee percentage

B Equipment budget × fee percentage

C Number of keys × laundry rate

D Hours × hourly rate per role

9

A camp serving paying retreat guests with a seasonal calendar receives which independence paragraph variant?

A Education (because it serves children)

B Religious / Church (because of the retreat framing)

C Hospitality (because of the operating model)

D Healthcare / Senior Living (because of the residential element)

The exhaust scope boundary in a Create The Edge proposal includes which of the following deliverables?

A Full mechanical system design including supply air balancing

B Hood model selection and fire suppression integration

C Duct connection sizes, CFM requirements, static pressure

D Sequencing of the mechanical system during equipment operation

11

The [Client Project Name] template carries an uncaught reconciliation error. Where does the error appear?

- **A** The independence paragraph uses the wrong sector variant
- **B** The narrative fee in Article II ($24,250) does not match the phase table total ($17,800)
- **C** The insurance limits fail to meet the RFP requirement
- **D** The Phase VI meeting count contradicts the cover letter promise

12

A travel reimbursement clause states the mileage rate as 65.5 cents per mile. The current 2026 IRS standard mileage rate is:

- **A** 62.5 cents per mile
- **B** 65.5 cents per mile
- **C** 66.5 cents per mile
- **D** 70.0 cents per mile

13

In the integration clause of Article I, what is the legal consequence of the phrase "the proposal, which is attached hereto, incorporated herein, and made a part of the agreement"?

- **A** The proposal is informational only and not enforceable
- **B** The proposal and the agreement become one legal document; everything in the cover letter is enforceable
- **C** The agreement supersedes the proposal in case of conflict
- **D** The proposal becomes enforceable only after the client countersigns

14

Which of the following per-diem rates applies to a Project Principal in 2026?

- **A** $1,275
- **B** $1,500
- **C** $1,600

15

When raising a flag in a proposal for an obvious scope gap, the correct framing is to:

A State directly that the RFP is incorrect

B Remain silent so as not to offend the architect of record

C Phrase the gap as a question or a recommendation, not as an accusation

D Add a separate fee for fixing the scope gap during Construction Administration

16

The Create The Edge proposal standard says travel must be itemized as a line item rather than bundled into the base fee. Which of the following is the correct rate for additional meetings beyond the contract count?

- **A** $150 per hour
- **B** $200 per hour
- **C** $225 per hour
- **D** $275 per hour

17

A proposal sent on October 9, 2026 is the seventh proposal sent that month. What is its correct filename under the Create The Edge filing convention?

- **A** 2026-October-07
- **B** 2026-10-07
- **C** 20261007
- **D** October_07_2026_Proposal

18

Which of the following is a forbidden follow-up move?

- **A** "I want to make sure we got the scope right for you."
- **B** "Does the timeline match your funding cycle?"
- **C** "Did you get our proposal?"
- **D** "Anything in the fee structure you want us to revisit before you take it to your board?"

19

[Department Manager]'s "no work begins until signed" rule means:

- **A** **Create The Edge** begins design work as soon as a verbal commitment is received from the client
- **B** **Create The Edge** begins design work only after the proposal, letter of intent, or executed AIA agreement is signed and returned
- **C** **Create The Edge** begins billable design work after a 50% deposit is received

20

The Create The Edge proposal turnaround standard from RFP receipt to proposal in the client's inbox is:

A One business day

B Three business days

C Five business days

D Ten business days

21

The pre-flight checklist has how many items?

A 10 items

B 12 items

C 16 items

D 25 items

22

The Construction Administration phase of a typical Create The Edge hospitality proposal includes how many in-fee site visits?

A One site visit only

B Two site visits: one for floor penetrations and one with a written report

C Three site visits at 30/60/90% completion

D Unlimited site visits during the warranty period

23

A variance letter is attached to a proposal when:

A The fee total is being reduced below the standard sector rate

B The scope item could trigger a code interpretation dispute, insurance underwriting question, or AHJ callback

C The client is asking for an extension of the proposal validity period

D The architect is requesting that **Create The Edge** assume design liability for the MEP scope

24

[Department Manager]'s principle "We took out Create The Edge. We took out the I." means:

A The firm name should be omitted from the cover page

B Clients buy results, not the consultant; the proposal should focus on what the client receives, not on us

C The proposal must avoid using first-person pronouns in any sentence

D The firm should keep its identity confidential during the bidding process

The Create The Edge 80% hit rate compares against an industry baseline of:

A 20%

B 30%

C 45%

D 60%

RULE OF THE HOUSE

Mark your answers. Do not check them yet. Read all twenty-five questions through once before turning to the answer legend. If you cannot answer five questions in a row without guessing, stop and re-read the relevant sub-modules before continuing. The test measures pattern recognition more than rote recall.

☑ ANSWER LEGEND · PART 1 OF 2

Answers and Explanations · Questions 1 through 13

> *The correct answer is given for each question, followed by the reasoning and a cross-reference to the sub-module where the concept was taught. If an explanation surprises you, return to the source sub-module and re-read with the answer in hand.*

QUESTION 1

Correct: C · Marketing differentiation instrument

The four instruments are **risk mitigation**, **scope and timeline**, **fee**, and **coordination**. Marketing differentiation is a benefit of doing the four instruments well, not one of the instruments themselves. See **G.1**.

QUESTION 2

Correct: B · Two paragraphs: context plus scope

The Two-Paragraph Rule states the cover letter opens with exactly two substantive paragraphs: one establishing context (project goal, impact, critical event, emotional and rational drivers) and one establishing scope (what we will do, what it will cost in equipment terms, how we will coordinate). Three- and four-paragraph openings dilute the message; one paragraph buries it. See **G.5**.

QUESTION 3

Correct: B · Emotional layer (impact, recognition, relief)

Decisions are made emotionally and justified rationally. After the technical presentation lands the Rational layer, the contract decision pivots on the Emotional layer: does this consultant make the client feel safer, more competent, more capable of delivering the impact they promised their stakeholders. See **G.3** and the Ishikawa five-layer model.

QUESTION 4

Correct: C · Loved (community impact)

K-12 districts are dominated by the Loved layer because nutrition program directors are accountable to a board and a community that measures success through student outcomes. The Paid layer matters (USDA reimbursement, energy savings) but the proposal that highlights graduation-rate impact, breakfast participation, and community pride wins consistently. See **G.4**.

QUESTION 5

Correct: C · Country club kitchen and bar

receive different sector-specific variants: K-12 gets Education, correctional gets Correctional, hospitals get Healthcare/Senior Living. See **G.8** and **G.16**.

QUESTION 6

Correct: B · SD 20% · DD 25% · CD 30% · BN 10% · CA 15%

The OS-default phase split (no Programming, no Equipment Survey) is 20/25/30/10/15, totaling 100%. This is the foundation pattern. [Client Project Name] and other foodservice work modify this with Programming and Equipment Survey phases that pull percentages away from CD and CA. F&B work modifies it to 20/30/30/5/15 because bid-phase work is heavier with bar fixtures. See **G.6**.

QUESTION 7

Correct: C · 3,000 pounds

The 15-lb laundry rule: 200 keys × 15 lbs per person per day = 3,000 lbs total daily soiled laundry. Divided by a 7-hour working day, that is approximately 429 lbs per working hour. The equipment sizing logic flows from that: 200-lb dryers required, two washers, three dryers. See **G.10** Method C and the laundry sizing calculator.

QUESTION 8

Correct: A · Square footage × sector rate × fee percentage

Method A: SF × $/SF (sector rate) = equipment budget, then equipment budget × fee percentage (typically 5% for hospitality, varying by sector) = fee. Method B works backward from a known equipment budget. Method C uses the 15-lb laundry rule for laundry-driven projects. Method D in the question is a description of the labor-build approach used to verify Method A or B. See **G.10**.

QUESTION 9

Correct: C · Hospitality (because of the operating model)

The independence paragraph variant is chosen by the operating model, not the demographic of the eaters. [Client Project Name] looks like education on first read because it serves children, but it has paying retreat guests, a seasonal calendar, and a brand promise built around hospitality. Pick the variant that matches how the operator runs the business. See **G.8** and **G.15**.

QUESTION 10

Correct: C · Duct connection sizes, CFM requirements, static pressure

The exhaust scope boundary is precise and deliberate: **Create The Edge** provides three deliverables · (1) duct connection sizes, (2) CFM requirements, (3) static pressure. The engineer designs the full mechanical system including supply air balancing, sequencing, hood model selection, and fire suppression integration. Holding this boundary protects us from scope creep on every project. See **G.15-p9** and **G.16-p6**.

QUESTION 11

Correct: B · The narrative fee ($24,250) does not match the phase table total ($17,800)

The [Client Project Name] template carries a $6,450 discrepancy between the narrative paragraph in Article II and the sum of the phase table. The fix is procedural: lock the total first using Method A, B, or C; apply the phase percentages to the locked total; verify the sum equals the narrative. [Department Manager] uses this template as a teaching test for every new hire. See **G.15-p13**.

QUESTION 12

Correct: C · 66.5 cents per mile

The current 2026 IRS standard mileage rate is 66.5 cents. Both the [Client Project Name] and F&B templates list 65.5 cents, which is one year stale. The pre-flight checklist item 13 catches this discrepancy. Always verify against the current IRS rate before sending. See **G.13** and **G.15-p14**.

QUESTION 13

Correct: B · The proposal and the agreement become one legal document; everything in the cover letter is enforceable

The integration clause in Article I is the most important sentence in any **Create The Edge** proposal. It binds the cover letter and the consultation agreement into one document for legal purposes. Anything stated in the cover letter is contractually enforceable. This is why the cover letter and the agreement must agree on scope, phases, fees, meetings, and timeline. See **G.15-p5**.

> Halfway. Twelve questions to go on the next page. Score yourself if you wish, but do not stop the assessment to course-correct. The pattern recognition the test measures is built only through reading all twenty-five questions and explanations in sequence.

☑ ANSWER LEGEND · PART 2 OF 2

Answers and Explanations · Questions 14 through 25

QUESTION 14

Correct: B · $1,500

2026 per-diem rates: Project Principal $1,500. Senior Project Manager and Project Manager both $1,275. Per-diem rates apply when a team member spends a full day on a site visit and replace the hourly billing for that day. See **G.13**.

QUESTION 15

Correct: C · Phrase the gap as a question or a recommendation, not as an accusation

[Department Manager]'s flag-raising practice: questions earn meetings; problems lose work. The correct framing is "we recommend confirming..." or "our experience suggests..." or "we note that..." Never "the RFP is incorrect," never silence, never adding a separate fee. The flag in the proposal reads as expertise; the flag in the kickoff meeting reads as a complaint. See **G.14**.

QUESTION 16

Correct: C · $225 per hour

Additional meetings beyond the contract count bill at $225 per hour. This is the Project Manager hourly rate and the standard for additional meeting billing across all sectors. The rate appears in every phase that allows additional meetings. See **G.13**.

QUESTION 17

Correct: B · 2026-10-07

The Year-Month-XX convention uses YYYY-MM-XX format. Four-digit year, two-digit month (numeric, not the spelled name), two-digit sequence number within that month. The seventh proposal sent in October 2026 is 2026-10-07. The convention sorts alphabetically and chronologically at the same time. See **G.19**.

QUESTION 18

Correct: C · "Did you get our proposal?"

"Did you get our proposal?" assumes incompetence on the client's end and creates a defensive dynamic. The approved follow-up questions all frame the conversation around helping the client succeed, not around pressuring them to decide. See **G.19**.

QUESTION 19

> The "no work begins until signed" clause appears in the Authorization block of every **Create The Edge** proposal. Verbal commitments do not bind the firm. A signed proposal, a signed letter of intent, or an executed AIA agreement does. Internal hours are not billed to the project until the signature arrives. See **G.15-p15**.

QUESTION 20

Correct: B · Three business days

[Department Manager]'s three-day turnaround standard. Day 1: read RFP, identify sector, choose template, assign team, work the fee logic. Day 2: draft cover letter, tailor scope language, build fee table, select SF 330. Day 3: pre-flight check, edits, file under naming convention, send. See **G.19**.

QUESTION 21

Correct: C · 16 items

The pre-flight checklist has sixteen items organized across five categories: Narrative (4), Scope (5), Fee (4), and Operations/Brand (3). The check takes twelve minutes once the writer is fluent in the items. It is not abbreviated for known clients and not skipped when deadlines are tight. See **G.17**.

QUESTION 22

Correct: B · Two site visits: one for floor penetrations and one with a written report

The two-site-visit standard is the minimum for any **Create The Edge** CA scope. Floor penetration check happens before the slab is poured to avoid demolition rework. The punch-list visit happens after equipment installation but before substantial completion. Additional visits bill at the $1,600 PM per-diem rate. See **G.15-p12** and **G.16-p8**.

QUESTION 23

Correct: B · When the scope item could trigger a code interpretation dispute, insurance underwriting question, or AHJ callback

[Department Manager]'s working test for a variance letter. The letter costs one hour of writing. The dispute it prevents costs ten hours of recovery plus the relationship damage. Variance letters are formal flags attached to the proposal but they do not modify the consultation agreement. See **G.14**.

QUESTION 24

Correct: B · Clients buy results, not the consultant; the proposal should focus on what the client receives, not on us

The foundational principle. The sentence "We took out Create The Edge. We took out the I." appears on the wall of the [Company HQ City] office. It is the test that every proposal sentence must pass. If the sentence starts with "**Create The Edge** has..." or "I will..." rewrite it. The client buys results. The credentials live in the qualifications section, not in the cover letter opener. See **G.20**.

QUESTION 25

Correct: B · 30%

The industry baseline conversion rate for foodservice consulting is 30%, or a 5:1 proposal-to-win ratio. **Create The Edge**'s 2024 conversion rate is 80%, or a 1.2:1 ratio.

paragraphs, the pre-flight checklist, and the follow-up protocol. None of these are clever. They are simply the work, done every time, without shortcuts. See **G.0** and **G.20**.

> **EXPERT INSIGHT · MARKETING DIRECTOR**
>
> *"A score of twenty or above means you can lead drafts. A score of twenty-two or above means you can lead drafts and review someone else's. Below eighteen means we read together. Below fifteen means you go back to the first sub-module and start over. There is no shame in starting over. There is only the timeline you build for yourself by treating the work as worth getting right."*

♦ FLASHCARDS · REFERENCE GRID

Fifteen Cards · Front and Back

> *Fifteen flashcards covering the operational vocabulary of Module G. Read the front, recall the back, then check. The grid below shows both sides for review. The next page hosts an interactive flip widget for practice; the page after that contains printable cut-cards you can keep on your desk through the first ninety days.*

#	FRONT	BACK
1	**RFQ vs RFP vs IDIQ vs On-Call**	RFQ: Request for Qualifications, asks "are you qualified." RFP: Request for Proposal, asks "what would you do." IDIQ: Indefinite Delivery / Indefinite Quantity, master agreement for repeat task orders. On-Call: standing engagement for as-needed services. (Section F)
2	**The Four Instruments**	Risk Mitigation, Scope and Timeline, Fee, Coordination. Every **Create The Edge** proposal is built on these four interlocking instruments. Marketing differentiation is a benefit, not an instrument. (G.1)
3	**The Decision Matrix Split**	50% Rational, 50% Emotional. The Rational layer is square footage, FTE, budget, code. The Emotional layer is impact, relief, recognition. Most decisions are made emotionally and justified rationally. (G.3)
4	**Made / Paid / Loved**	Made: operational efficiency (the kitchen runs better). Paid: financial return (cost recovery, energy savings, throughput). Loved: community impact (the people we serve are better off). Every project is dominated by one of the three. Lead with that. (G.4)
5	**Two-Paragraph Rule**	Cover letter opens with exactly two substantive paragraphs. Paragraph one is context (Made/Paid/Loved + Ishikawa). Paragraph two is scope (square footage + design moves). No firm history. No vendor lists. (G.5)
6	**The Five Phases**	SD (Schematic Design), DD (Design Development), CD (Construction Documents), BN (Bidding / Negotiations), CA (Construction Administration). Renovation adds Programming/Conceptual and Equipment Survey on the front end. (G.6)
7	**OS Default vs Delta Variant**	OS default split: 20% / 25% / 30% / 10% / 15%. [Client Project Name] variant (renovation foodservice):

		20% / 25% / 35% / 2% / 18%. F&B variant (with bar): 20% / 30% / 30% / 5% / 15%. Pick the split that matches actual work intensity per phase. (G.6, G.15, G.16)
8	**Method A (Fee Calculation)**	Square footage × sector $/SF = equipment budget. Equipment budget × fee percentage (typically 5%) = base fee. Used for new construction with a clean program. (G.10)
9	**Method B (Fee Calculation)**	Known equipment budget × fee percentage = base fee. Used when the client has already specified an equipment budget cap. Fee percentage adjusts for project complexity. (G.10)
10	**Method C · The 15-Lb Laundry Rule**	(Keys × 15 lbs/person/day) ÷ 7 working hours = lbs/hr. Washer 200 lb / 45 min = 267 lbs/hr. Dryer 200 lb / 60 min = 200 lbs/hr. Used for hospitality and resort laundry sizing. (G.10)
11	**F&B vs Foodservice Framing**	F&B framing applies whenever a bar is in scope: hotels, restaurants, country clubs, conference centers. Foodservice framing applies everywhere else: K-12, healthcare, correctional, religious, morgue/forensic. (G.8, G.16)
12	**Travel and Expense Rates**	$1,600/day site visit fee (PM). $0.665/mile beyond 50 miles from [Company HQ] GA (IRS 2026 rate). $225/hour for meetings beyond contract count. All line items. Never bundled. (G.13)
13	**The Three-Day Turnaround + Year-Month-XX Filing**	RFP receipt to client inbox: three business days. File naming: 2026-MM-NN where NN is the sequential proposal number for that month. Convention enforced firm-wide. (G.19)
14	**Rejected Email Phrases & Approved Follow-Up**	Forbidden: "just checking in," "hope this finds you well," "did you receive our proposal." Approved: direct, technical, name what is attached and what response is needed by when. Follow-up frame: "help YOU succeed," never "help **Create The Edge** win." (G.19)
15	**The 80%/30% Hit Rate**	Industry-baseline proposal-to-contract conversion: 30%, or roughly 5 proposals per win. **Create The Edge** 2024 conversion: 80%, or roughly 1.2 proposals per win. The gap is the four-instrument architecture, the pre-flight check, and the [Department Manager]-and-[Company Owner] review chain applied consistently. (G.20)

Print the flashcards. Carry them. Quiz yourself between meetings. The fifteen cards above contain the operational vocabulary new hires use through the first ninety days. Memorization is not the point. Fluent recall is. When a chef asks about zero-step bartending in a sales call, you should answer without hesitation. When an architect asks about the 15-lb laundry rule, you should know the formula by heart. The cards are the path to that fluency.

FLASHCARDS · INTERACTIVE

Tap the Card to See the Answer

The same fifteen cards, one at a time. Read the front, attempt the back from memory, then tap to check. Use the dots below to jump to any card. Use Previous and Next to step through in order.

RULE OF THE HOUSE

Active recall outperforms passive re-reading. Read the front. Say the back out loud before you flip. Even if your answer is partial, the act of attempting the recall is what transfers the content into working memory. The widget is designed for that discipline.

MODULE G · STUDY TOOLS

✄ PRINTABLE CUT-OUT STUDY CARDS

Print, Cut, Carry

> *The fifteen cards arranged for printing. Each card is sized to roughly 3.5 × 5 inches. Cut along the dashed borders. Keep them in your bag. Pull one out between meetings. Within thirty days, the vocabulary will be muscle memory.*

RFQ vs RFP vs IDIQ vs On-Call

RFQ: are you qualified. RFP: what would you do. IDIQ: master agreement for repeat task orders. On-Call: standing as-needed services.

The Four Instruments

Risk Mitigation · Scope and Timeline · Fee · Coordination. Four interlocking instruments behind every **Create The Edge** proposal.

Decision Matrix Split

50% Rational, 50% Emotional. Decisions made emotionally; justified rationally.

Made / Paid / Loved

Made: operational efficiency. Paid: financial return. Loved: community impact. Lead with the dominant layer.

Two-Paragraph Rule

Paragraph one: context (Made/Paid/Loved + Ishikawa). Paragraph two: scope. No firm history. No vendor lists.

The Five Phases

SD · DD · CD · BN · CA. Renovation adds Programming/Conceptual and Equipment Survey on the front.

OS Default vs Variants

OS default: 20/25/30/10/15. Renovation: 20/25/35/2/18. F&B with bar: 20/30/30/5/15.

Method A

SF × sector $/SF = equipment budget. Equipment budget × fee % = base fee. New construction.

Known equipment budget × fee % = base fee. Used when client specifies budget cap.

Method C · 15-Lb Laundry Rule

(Keys × 15 lbs/day) ÷ 7 hrs = lbs/hr. Washer 267 lbs/hr. Dryer 200 lbs/hr.

F&B vs Foodservice

F&B when bar in scope. Foodservice for schools, healthcare, correctional, religious, morgue.

Travel & Expense Rates

$1,600/day site visit. $0.665/mile beyond 50 miles. $225/hour additional meetings. Always line items.

3-Day + Year-Month-XX

RFP to client inbox: 3 business days. File 2026-MM-NN. Convention enforced firm-wide.

Rejected vs Approved Email

Forbidden: "just checking in," "hope this finds you well." Approved: direct, technical, attached, expected response.

The 80% Hit Rate

Industry: 30%. **Create The Edge** 2024: 80%. The gap is discipline applied consistently.

MODULE G · GLOSSARY

The Operational Vocabulary, A to Z

> *Every term that appears in Module G, defined precisely. Use this as a reference companion while reading proposals, drafting your own, or hearing terms in client meetings. The definitions are **Create The Edge**-specific and reflect how we use the vocabulary internally, which may differ from how other firms or trade publications use it.*

TERM	DEFINITION
4-Instrument Architecture	The four interlocking instruments of a **Create The Edge** proposal: Risk Mitigation, Scope and Timeline, Fee, Coordination. Every proposal contains all four. Mismatch in any one undermines the others. (G.1)
BIM Coordination	Building Information Modeling. Three-dimensional design coordination tying foodservice equipment to architectural, structural, MEP, and interior design models. Listed as a **Create The Edge** qualification on cover letter page 3. (G.15)
Bullseye Selection	The discipline of selecting SF 330 past-project examples by relevance to the current RFQ (sector match, scale match, budget tier match), not by recency or visual quality. (G.0, Section F)
Construction Administration (CA)	The fifth phase of a standard proposal. **Create The Edge** services include submittal/shop drawing review, RFI response, and site inspections. Default two site visits: one for floor penetrations, one for the punch list. (G.6, G.15)
Construction Documents (CD)	The third phase. Final 1/4" scale equipment plans, plumbing/electrical connection plans, building conditions plans, elevations, specifications in Masterspec format. (G.6)
Consultation Agreement	The legal portion of the proposal. Contains the Witnesseth clauses, Articles I through V, fee table, hourly rates, travel reimbursement, suspension/termination terms, and authorization signature block. Begins on page 4 of a 15-page foodservice proposal. (G.9, G.15)
Cover Letter	The first three pages of a proposal. Date, recipient block, reference line, two-paragraph opener, sector-specific independence paragraph, equipment estimate range, phase intro, insurance schedule, qualifications, closing, signature. (G.7, G.15, G.16)
D.C.V. (Demand Control	An exhaust-hood system that modulates fan speed and ventilation rate based on cooking activity. Used in F&B

Ventilation)	proposals as an energy-efficiency design move. (G.16)
Decision Matrix	The 50% rational / 50% emotional split that governs how clients evaluate proposals. Most decisions are made emotionally and justified rationally. (G.3)
Delivery Markers (30/60/90/100)	Intermediate completion percentages used in design-build engagements to mark progress within a phase. 30% is concept-locked; 60% is detail-developed; 90% is bid-ready; 100% is permit-ready.
Design Development (DD)	The second phase. Revit plans at 1/4" = 1'-0", equipment manufacturer data book, exhaust requirements (CFM, static pressure, duct sizes), estimate of probable cost. (G.6)
Equipment Survey & Report	Renovation-only phase. Site visit, condition assessment, MEP load identification, equipment cost estimate for replacement and reuse. [Client Project Name] Phase II. (G.6, G.15)
F&B Framing	Independence paragraph variant used whenever a bar is in scope. Applies to hotels, restaurants, country clubs, conference centers. Reads as "specialty food and beverage consultant." (G.8, G.16)
Fee Logic	The three methods (A, B, C) used to calculate the base fee. Method A: SF × $/SF × fee %. Method B: known equipment budget × fee %. Method C: 15-lb laundry rule for hospitality laundry sizing. (G.10, G.11)
Five-Phase Structure	The OS-default proposal structure: SD / DD / CD / BN / CA. Renovation projects extend the front with Programming/Conceptual and Equipment Survey. (G.6)
Flag ([Department Manager]'s flag practice)	The discipline of raising scope risks in the proposal itself, framed as questions rather than complaints. A flag in the proposal looks like expertise; a flag in the kickoff meeting looks like a complaint. (G.14)
Foodservice Framing	Independence paragraph variant used for non-bar projects: K-12, correctional, healthcare/senior living, religious, morgue/forensic. (G.8)
IDIQ (Indefinite Delivery / Indefinite Quantity)	A master agreement type used by federal and large institutional clients. **Create The Edge** qualifies under the master agreement, then receives task orders against it. (Section F)
Independence Paragraph	The paragraph in every **Create The Edge** proposal that states the firm's vendor-neutral, non-commissioned position. Six sector-specific variants exist: Hospitality, Correctional, Education, Religious/Church, Healthcare/Senior Living, Morgue/Forensic. (G.8)
Ishikawa Five-Layer	The five-layer decision model: Impact, Critical Event, Emotional Decisions, Rational Decisions, Preferences. Used

	to structure the first body paragraph of every cover letter. (G.3)
JC/initials	The authorship marker placed below Company Owner's signature line in every proposal. JC stands for Company Owner; the initials after the slash identify the actual writer (mk for the proposal lead Klein, aks for [Department Manager], sai for Sarah the AI strategist). Internal record only. (G.15, G.16)
Letter of Objective	A three-sentence framing statement that precedes the cover letter on RFP responses. States **Create The Edge**'s understanding of the client's goal in the client's own language. (G.7)
Made / Paid / Loved	The three-pillar framework for identifying what dominates a client's buying decision. Made: operational efficiency. Paid: financial return. Loved: community impact. (G.4)
Masterspec Format	The AIA-standard specification format used for foodservice equipment specifications. Required by most architects of record on US projects. (G.6, G.15)
Method A / B / C	The three fee-calculation methods. A: SF-driven. B: equipment-budget-driven. C: laundry-load-driven (15-lb rule). (G.10)
Pre-Flight Checklist	The 16-item verification protocol every proposal passes before sending. Maps to lessons in G.0 through G.16. (G.17)
Programming Phase	Renovation-only Phase I. Written narrative covering codes, typical equipment requirements, space relationship flow, block diagram, equipment budget. [Client Project Name] Phase I. (G.6, G.15)
Risk Mitigation Instrument	One of the four instruments. Identifies and addresses scope risk, schedule risk, code risk, and financial risk in the proposal itself, before the work begins. (G.1, G.14)
RFP (Request for Proposal)	A formal procurement document requesting a written response describing how a firm would execute the work. Receives a full proposal in return. (Section F)
RFQ (Request for Qualifications)	A formal procurement document requesting evidence that a firm is qualified to bid. Receives a qualifications package, not a fee proposal. (Section F)
Schematic Design (SD)	The first phase of the five-phase OS default. Plan at 1/8" to 1/4" = 1'-0" scale, preliminary equipment cost estimate, schematic design submittal for approval before proceeding. (G.6)
SF 330	The federal standard form for submitting past-project qualifications. **Create The Edge** selects three to five SF 330 examples per RFQ by bullseye relevance. (Section F)

Two-Paragraph Rule	The cover letter opens with exactly two substantive paragraphs: context plus scope. No firm history. No vendor lists. No equipment philosophy. (G.5)
Variance Letter	A formal attachment to a proposal addressing health code variances, insurance carve-outs, or non-standard scope. Part of the proposal package; does not modify the consultation agreement. (G.14)
Year-Month-XX Filing	The **Create The Edge** file naming convention: YYYY-MM-NN where NN is the sequential proposal number for that month. Used across the proposal lifecycle from draft to executed contract. (G.19)
Zero-Step Bartending	An F&B bar design principle ensuring all ingredients, tools, and equipment are within the bartender's arm reach. Maximizes drink throughput and guest interaction time. Named in every **Create The Edge** F&B proposal that includes a bar. (G.16)

FROM THE FILES

The glossary is the dictionary, not the textbook. Use it to verify a term's **Create The Edge**-specific meaning when you encounter it in a proposal you are reviewing, or when a colleague uses it in a meeting and you want to confirm you heard it correctly. The sub-module references in parentheses point you back to where the term is taught in context. The textbook is the rest of Module G. The dictionary lives here.

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